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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JSJ9J5qVxoc
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:13:32] okay good morning it's 9 a.m and i'll well it's 902 excuse me and i'll call this meeting to order i'll note that i've approved the remote participation of miss mcpherson under the board's bylaws in 2.2-3708.3 b4 of the code of virginia because she is in california visiting family before we begin on the first agenda item the superintendent has some key updates for the board and the public that she would like to provide so with that superintendent gullickson great thank you good morning i'm president creasy members of the board um first i want to recognize

[00:14:09] some of the individuals in our front row along with their team members uh chief conway and the entire early childhood care and education team had a wildly successful vqb5 rollout last week and it includes our new honor roll system that you're going to hear more about in item a but i had the opportunity to join uh one of our house of delegate members mike cherry in atlanta a few weeks ago with a bunch of lawmakers from 14 southern states and we do not

[00:14:48] get to have the recognition enough about what jenna and the team have established here in virginia on the preeminent public private high quality child care marketplace that's grounded in parent demand and gives incredible options for infants or birth to five-year-olds as well as some of our school-age

kids and so this team has truly designed the gold standard of excellence for birth to five models in the country and i want to put it on the record for the public who are not

[00:15:24] able to join us at that press conference that if you have not checked out our portal of late they've been updated and i hope you will explore the options in your community soon and just know we are not done innovating and leading the way yet the early childhood commission will get an update from jenna and the team later today on the progress being made with our new digital wallet and other options to continue to try to lower costs for families while maintaining rigor and high quality and excellence for our youngest learners so although you're going to hear more

[00:16:02] from her in a minute board i wanted to make sure that you were aware of just the deep respect by other state leaders we have multiple states seeking to come to virginia with a fly-in to study and learn from the team so i couldn't be more proud and wanted to make sure i started the day with that secondly we have been very thankful for all of the collaboration with school divisions on making sure that all of our data is set on their student outcomes for our k-12 accountability

[00:16:41] system that builds off the great momentum from our early childhood system and so we are now in the phase where we have made sure that we're complying with the best data governance practices and finalizing the agreement with a third party that's one of our public higher ed institutions to independently validate our school performance and support framework data and outcomes for each school and division so that we can ensure transparency and the highest level of integrity for the board to have great confidence in the work of our incredible team and so once this

[00:17:21] independent validation is complete our school division leaders will receive both their division and individual school summary reports along with resources to help with communication to their stakeholders and the accountability data will then be made to the public no less than one week after the school divisions have received that data. We're working to avoid surprises so that they've had the opportunity to review these final reports. So we're very excited about this external validation and delivering on these best practices as a norm at the agency and wanted to give an

[00:17:58] update there. On federal funding, because we get a lot of questions about that, so I want to make sure to emphasize that for Virginia and the Virginia Department of Education, all of our federal funds are being delivered as expected daily, and there's been no disruption or cuts to any of our reimbursements to the Department of Education. I'm going to emphasize that again for those tuning in now. There have been no disruptions or cuts to the reimbursements for

[00:18:34] the Virginia Department of Education. I know board members, you have been getting questions and those in the field. So this is true. Many of you know we have a variety of funding sources from multiple federal agencies, including the U.S. Department of Education, Health and Human Services, the department of labor department of agriculture and more and so we want to reassure everyone that's tuning in that the continued support has allowed us to maintain planned programs staffing at the agency and services for our students during the school year without any interruption and we are

[00:19:13] in close communication with the federal contacts and we'll be keeping the board here and stakeholders aware and informed of any changes should that occur but right now all dollars are flowing as intended the last major update i wanted to discuss is on proficiency and this push to higher expectations since our last board meeting two more states have taken action and actually worked towards

[00:19:49] lowering their expectations for students and i am incredibly proud that virginia is being recognized in local and national outlets for our commitment to having high expectations for every student i have been very blessed with phone calls from parents that have said thank you for believing in my child we know it's a lot of work but we know that they're going to be set up for success and you will hear more from the team here shortly but we have had thousands of virginians who have either attended listening sessions over the last three weeks or written comments

[00:20:27] to the agency to help us deliver on this commitment and make sure that we do it in a thoughtful and intentional way for leveling up on these more rigorous expectations and i also want to recognize the department staff first deputy superintendent booker dwyer and her team but also this has been a really great illustration that we've been talking to the board about modernizing the agency breaking down silos and really instilling a collaborative community within the agency moving from compliance towards collaboration and support with the field and we

[00:21:06] have had department staff in addition to our assessment and accountability teams they have had partnership from staff and leaders across multiple divisions and offices who have attended listening sessions who have helped to field questions who have helped to inform additional supports that are underway technical opportunities for educators parents and students to really be set up for success and so um this is proof that this new shift in our agency is working and a lot of

[00:21:41] that is behind the scenes and so we wanted to make sure the board was aware um that these aren't just arbitrary uh statements but we're seeing the work in action and kids are benefiting um as a result so while there's more to do i can't be more proud of the progress made in the last few weeks And just thank you, President Creasy, for the time to make a few remarks.

[00:22:05] Well, I would be remiss if I didn't say something, too, about just the long-term commitment that Jenna and her team have had to the outcomes that we are finally seeing.

[00:22:23] I mean, beginning years ago and, you know, starting with the school readiness committee when you first came on, Jenna, you know, having been a part of that committee and then the early childhood advisory committee. And then, I mean, we have just taken all of these different forms and iterations of trying to get to the point where we have now come today.

[00:22:45] And so I know for your team, this is truly a moment of, you know, finality to some degree. I know we're never finished doing this kind of work to make things better, to prepare kids better, to get to our K-12 systems.

[00:23:04] And I just thank all of you for your commitment to moving this continually down the field to get to that goalpost that you all set for yourselves and for the Commonwealth and for our providers across the Commonwealth, whether they be public providers or private providers. I just appreciate the commitment that you all have had to ensuring the success and the quality, the high quality, not just quality, because we can say quality, but when we really, really get to the

[00:23:39] nitty-gritty we want for our own children and your entire team has seen and has committed to and put their hearts and souls into what they would want for their own children for the commonwealth's children and I'm so incredibly thankful and so happy to see sort of this point where we have come today so it's been a long road but thank you for your longevity and commitment to the process we really do appreciate it and the commonwealth appreciates it too um and so i'm

[00:24:17] looking forward to hearing for from um our presentations today but i guess that brings us to your presentation um and we will go ahead and get started with that do you all have the slides Yes, yes. Perfect. Okay. Well, good morning, everyone. That was a wonderful introduction, and I very much appreciate the kind words from the superintendent, and thank you very much, President Creasy.

[00:24:53] i'm jenna conway i'm our chief of early learning and specialized populations i want to take a moment to recognize at this moment we have 175 members of the division of early childhood care and education many who are out today inspecting centers evaluating classrooms preparing for deep dives, making sure that folks get paid. And, you know, it truly takes a team effort and feel very appreciative that I get to work with that extraordinary team located across the Commonwealth.

[00:25:33] What I am pleased to cover today is an update on last week's release and to give you a point in time on what we know about uh quality in our public private early childhood care and education system i know that some of you are newer to the board and so i'll start sort of more broadly with school readiness in virginia um i'll then go into how we measure quality in virginia i think that's important so as we can sort of delineate some of the differences between vqb5 and our school and performance support framework. I'll then talk in details about the results and then I will note

[00:26:12] next steps. I also have as my lifeline today Assistant Superintendent Aaron Carroll who has been working with me for nearly a decade in both Louisiana and Virginia to support the strengthening of early childhood systems and then our true expert on VQB5 our Director of VQB5 Chris Myers.

[00:26:31] So we'll start as we always do if you move to the slide on shared vision on what we're trying to to achieve together. And as President Christie noted, it really takes a sustained effort moving away from a focus on what program am I, what building am I in, to really recognizing a full system, where whether you're in a school, in a private childcare center, in a faith-based preschool, in a family day home, or in a Head Start program, that across those different experiences in classrooms, that there's a shared goal of making sure

[00:27:07] that every kid in Virginia has the opportunity to come to kindergarten ready. We know that parent choice and parents as our children's first and most important educators need to be able to choose across those options. What you might want as for your infant child in rural Virginia might look different than your preschooler in a more urban setting and making sure that we're thinking about that full range of public-private options.

[00:27:31] We also know that parents want to choose quality, as President Creasy noted, and that practitioners and stakeholders want to make sure that there is accountability for public dollars and i'll talk a lot about continuous improvement and how our system supports that and ultimately early childhood plays has this unique sort of dual role as i'll talk about in some of the data around not only supporting kids learning and development in that kind of most fundamental first five-year period but also supporting our working families to work go to job training school and pursue greater self-sufficiency for themselves and for their families.

[00:28:09] So as we move on, I want to sort of start with where we are. And I think this is an important point, particularly because this current statistic on kindergarten readiness represents an example of how we have worked really closely with the field to raise the bar because that was the right thing for kids.

[00:28:29] So if you were to compare this statistic where 51% of kids last year entered kindergarten ready and as a reminder entering ready means that you're fully ready in literacy math social skills and self-regulation so we look at the whole child but this number is slightly lower in years than in years past this is in large part because we work very closely with the university of virginia virginia literacy partnerships to fully overhaul what was formerly known as pals and is not now known as vals and that we started in preschool and as you know and and as you've heard from my colleague, Assistant Superintendent Wallace and others, right,

[00:29:07] is really, really important work around supporting all students in Virginia to be able to read. When we went from PALS to VALS, we expanded what we were evaluating. We went just not just evaluating some of those skills that are necessary for decoding, so, you know, knowing letters and sounds, but actually looking at language, how kids express language, how kids comprehend language, storytelling, of those more complex skills. And as a result of that, you see a drop from the prior year.

[00:29:38] On the other hand, when we talk with educators, when we engage with families, and we think about this work, it's critically important that if you move to the next slide, that we really capture that language information, right? Because language is a very important predictor of future learning. And so that's just an example where, again, well, under this board's oversight over the course of last few years we've been able to raise the bar but it is the right thing for kids because if we can get our educators of three and four year olds to really focus on not only some of those key skills related to decoding and preparing to read but also language development that that will

[00:30:16] carry with kids throughout their educational experience school matter school readiness matters not only if you talk to a kindergarten teacher who will say I can tell you on day one who which kids right whether it was in head start or pre-k in a school or in a child care setting in a family day home i can tell you who is coming in ready to learn prepared to work with others i see miss kilgore nodding like right it's very different but that's not all that it matters for if you look at virginia data if you look at the kindergarten readiness predicts third grade reading basically across thousands and thousands of different elementary schools with very different experiences even across that you

[00:30:55] How you look at the beginning of kindergarten using the PALS is highly predictive of where you will be in third grade and what that means. So what this chart means for those in that blue or navy bar, that if we can get you coming into kindergarten ready, if we can think about the system as a whole, that regardless of kind of experiences across K-3, we can get you to third grade and nearly all of you will be reading.

[00:31:19] In sharp contrast, if you come in least ready, and this is that yellow bar, it basically becomes a coin toss, right? And so how do we work as a system? We have extraordinary kindergarten first, second, and third grade educators, but if we can get all of our kids prepared, then we will see much better outcomes in elementary school and beyond. And so that's kind of an important point as we think about why this matters. We also know when we look at our data that it is sort of less important which program you're in, that you just have access to a program altogether. So we know that early childhood matters for readiness.

[00:31:55] That our kids who look least likely, least ready coming in are our children in low-income households whose parents report no preschool experience whatsoever, right? So again, our focus is on

how do we embrace all of the various public-private programs that want to take public dollars and serve our kids in greatest need and ultimately think about that system and supporting that system.

[00:32:16] It looks different than just school buildings, right? We've got 2,000 family child care homes, 3,000 licensed child care centers, just up under 1,000 public schools, 880 religiously exempt programs, and 46 Head Start grantees who are located in over 360 sites in local government, in private child aid centers, and in schools.

[00:32:38] So, again, it's a very different mix. And the last statistic I'll share for you before pivoting to VQB5 is just helping you understand why do we still have so many kids coming to us even as birth rates in Virginia go down. And there's sort of while birth rates are dropping slightly, we are seeing a persistent trend going back over the last decade of more kids than ever before under the age of six having all available parents in the workforce.

[00:33:06] So that's now up to seven out of 10 Virginia children under the age of six have all available parents in the workforce. And what we hear from parents and what I'll be sharing, what we'll be hearing at the commission today, where parents need to have a place to send their kid. And it's for them, they want to be able to choose an option that is not only healthy and safe, but will put their kid on track for success.

[00:33:29] And it can't just be babysitting or custodial care. It has to be an environment and where their kids are supported to learn and to thrive. So with that, let me tell you a little bit about VQB5 and, as President Creasy described, our path forward over the last few years.

[00:33:44] Jenna, can we pause for a second? I think Superintendent Gullickson has a question. Sure. Jenna, last week at the press conference, one of the parents who spoke talked about that she had had her earliest learners in a variety of settings. And so for those who are just tuning in, can you talk a little bit more about that flexibility of dollars?

[00:34:06] you aren't necessarily putting your child just in one of these options or at an increment of time. There's that adaptability. Absolutely, there is that adaptability. And so partly, and we'll focus more on the quality today, but the superintendent raises a really important point.

[00:34:21] When you think of those settings on that slide, we have done a lot of work with our recent governors and the General Assembly to also fund these programs in a way that parents can choose across them. So we've taken the Child Care Subsidy Program, which functions as vouchers.

[00:34:40] We've got something called the Mixed Delivery, where we fund kind of classrooms in child care programs. We've got Virginia Preschool Initiative. We work alongside with Early Childhood Special Education, Head Start, and Early Head Start. And basically what it means is the choice system. And when we talk about the programs that take public dollars, whether that's one voucher to serve one low-income or in-need kid or whether it's entire classroom, all of those programs, when you take public dollars, agree to participate in BQB 5.

[00:35:09] And what that means is that for parents in the greatest need in Virginia, including many, many working families, that they can choose across their program. They might start as an infant when their child is an infant and choose a voucher. They might then switch to pre-K if their older children are there at a school.

[00:35:26] There is flexibility across the different funding sources and the different settings. What is consistent, and this is important when you think about both our desire to improve outcomes for kids and to kind of have accountability for public dollars, is that even though there's a lot of flexibility and parent choice, we measure these in an apple to apples way so that we can sort of help parents sort of think about how we choose what makes most sense for me and for my child at this moment in time.

[00:35:54] And as I'll talk about, that we can also sort of come to you, come to the General Assembly and say these are the outcomes, here's the experiences that kids are receiving across these different funding sources and across these different settings. That's a great question. So VQB 5, at a very high level, is required by law, so it sets this board in charge of establishing a measurement and improvement system.

[00:36:18] It is not optional. It is required for any program that takes public dollars, and it's always a choice to take public dollars. So that's Head Start, that's if you receive these child care vouchers, mixed delivery, Virginia preschool, early childhood special education. Its theory of change is that we have to focus less on inputs, but really get down to what is happening in classrooms.

[00:36:41] It's not appropriate at this age to kind of directly evaluate kids for stakes. You can imagine, right, if I were to bring a three-year-old here right now and we had a high-stakes test, it wouldn't work well for us and wouldn't work well for him or her. And so the focus is on what is sort of most proximate, what is most predictive of improving child outcomes while also recognizing that we can't kind of directly sort of have high stakes testing for toddlers right now.

[00:37:07] The two resources that Virginia relies on are sort of measuring interactions. And so that's very predictive of how much kids will learn using a nationally regarded tool known as the CLASS or the Classroom Assessment Scoring System. That is for infant classrooms, three 20-minute cycles, and for toddler and preschool, four 20-minute cycles.

[00:37:27] So this is not a walkthrough. This is an intensive observation across multiple domains and dimensions with lots of notes and a very precise score. And then we also are encouraging programs to use a curriculum. We believe in high-quality instructional materials. It is a choice, but if you do those two things, high-quality interactions, and you're using curriculum to support high-quality actions, our theory of change, which is aligned with the research suggests that kids in those classrooms will learn more and make more progress towards kindergarten readiness. So this just talks about the participation requirements so again as the

[00:38:02] superintendent noted it's an array of programs it's not just schools they if you take a public dollar you have to be a part of this and what being part of it means because there was a concern and President Creasy will remember this back in the early days that if we require put new requirements on programs that well private providers will just opt out whether that's private schools or private child care or private family day homes and what we found is actually the opposite right we have more private providers participating than ever before it's a reasonable expectation they have to fill out some information and link b5 they need to open up their classrooms for observations

[00:38:38] multiple times a year and just to make sure that they do that both fall and spring if you move to the next slide, what you'll see is that then kind of creates a very different mechanism for continuous quality improvement. Previously, many of our other rating systems looked at things like inputs, like do the educators have bachelor's degree? Do you have the right number of books? And while that is can have some value, it is really hard. Like the option for the teacher who doesn't have the bachelor's degree is go

off and purchase a really expensive degree, or the center director has to go They'll often purchase a lot of books and certain equipment.

[00:39:14] VQB5 takes a very different approach. There's much less of a cost related to doing this, but it provides -- because all you have to do is let these observations come in, but then it enables every single educator and leader in the system to have insight in an apples-to-apples way of what's happening in those classrooms, right, to get better.

[00:39:34] So we do fall and spring observations locally, every single classroom, and we have a third party that goes out and evaluates the consistency and accuracy of those observations. So if Mr. Monk and Ms. Kilgore are teachers in the four-year-old classroom, they will have an intensive observation in the fall, get that feedback, their leader will get that feedback, they'll have an intensive observation in the spring, they'll have that data.

[00:39:58] That helps them get better at their practice. It's not a generic professional development or training and technical assistance, it's deeply rooted in what those educators and what's happening in that classroom. It also means when Virginia, as it did last year, completes 31,000 of those observations, which represent 2.2 million minutes of insight, that's what parents find on that website, right?

[00:40:18] And they can really understand, okay, this is a place where I can trust, not only is it healthy and safe as determined by our Office of Child Care Health and Safety, but like kids are thriving because at the core of this, little kids, young children learn in the context of interactions with adults.

[00:40:35] And so just a really important, like from the outset, this is not only going to give you a specific three-digit score for every one of your 3,293 sites, but it also enables improvement, as I'll talk about as we go forward. So we rely, and a huge thank you should also go out into addition to the incredible staff of the Division of Early Childhood to the Virginia Early Childhood Foundation, who is our key state private partner, who then oversees our nine ready regions.

[00:41:04] so a relatively new entity in Virginia now codified in law. Businesses, government, nonprofits, everybody has the opportunity to compete every three years to be a Ready Region. We have nine entities right now that serve as our Ready Regions across the state. Some are United Ways, some are sort of standalone entities. They make sure we complete these observations, they build relationships, they get the data in the system, they help make enrollment work easier for families and they also do have family impact councils and we think about some of the change in early childhood making sure that families are at the center of that work that's hard to do from the

[00:41:42] state level and so we rely on our public private partnerships with ready regions to make sure that families are engaged every step of the way and we are so pleased and as president creasy noted this has been a long road but vqb5 is truly everywhere in the commonwealth we are 3 300 sites uh you'll see the kind of color coding in terms of the different types of sites but we are in every city and county in uh virginia and it takes a lot as somebody who has visited highland county our least populous county uh it is a lot and you'll see even over the eastern shore a lot of locations

[00:42:19] and i will note there were even eastern shore locations that were on our honor rolls but we are truly statewide in a scale um that was was hard to imagine before uh and last but not least just want to share i think we are trying to kind of really over time help families understand empowering choice having a dynamic marketplace really depends on making sure that families understand what client quality look

like why it matters we know it's really expensive for families it's probably the biggest investment they make outside of of housing and so doing work with chris

[00:42:55] and the team the ready regions our site partners to help folks understand what bqb5 is and why it matters has been a key goal of ours so with that let's move into the next section and we'll talk about the results so as uh the superintendent noted the governor the secretary the superintendent elected officials business leaders and parents came together last week to recognize the release of 3 293 quality profiles on our one-stop family portal i will note in the first 24 hours alone we

[00:43:29] We had 10,000 views of that site, and for a point of reference, we were excited just to get to 100,000 in the first year, and we got 10% there on the first day. In the first week, we were, as the team told me yesterday, just under 20,000. So it's just, you'll just see over time, there's a real utility.

[00:43:47] I should note, there's no other way for parents to get this information, right? They just can't be in the center for two or three hours to kind of observe, even if they visit, And I always encourage families to visit when they're thinking about what the right early childhood choice is for them. But it's hard to kind of sort of really sit in the classroom.

[00:44:05] This data is saying, we're going to do that work for you. We're going to go into every single classroom multiple times, and we're going to give you an accurate reflection of what kids are experiencing. We have the key messages here and how we've been sort of telling the story. One, it was a successful second year, and we are so pleased to have more programs than ever before participating.

[00:44:27] we are engaging families through the resources that I described and the portal we were very pleased and the reason we selected the circle preschool and sprout for our announcement last week is that they were both on the honor rolls and so we are elevating excellence and we are elevating improvement for nearly 500 sites across the state and I'll talk a little bit more about that in a minute it, we are seeing improvement in quality while we have more programs coming on and ultimately as we've talked about before, thanks to the investment of this governor and General Assembly,

[00:45:05] we are serving more kids with public dollars and impacting with VQB5 more kids than ever before. If you move forward into kind of a breakdown of the performance, and I'll just sort of go through the highlights, as Ms. Northern knows, I can get into the data and she's going have to wave her hand if there are questions but this is pretty wonky you know chris and i love it chris leads our deep dives in which we have 70 slides so this is only half of that miss northern um that we spend two hours with partners across the state in our nine nine deep dives but 31 258

[00:45:40] class observations were uh were completed the most we think in the country oftentimes if the superintendent or i are in other states presenting and i'll sort of say that number and they're like I think you added an extra zero. You must mean 3,100. I'm like, oh, no, no, like 31,000 observations, 2.2 million minutes of insight into what kids are experiencing. And at its core, it's a fairly complicated and complex tool. But as you understand that tool, you realize that this is what is good for kids. And so I've had many a child care teacher come up to me and be like, I was highly skeptical about this thing in the beginning. I've been

[00:46:18] doing this work for 20 years. I know babies, right? Like, I know babies better than you know babies. And yet, when you look at the kind of the details, what the kind of practices that this tool calls for,

we find over time that it really resonates. We think this is the reason that 10 years in, in Louisiana, that they continue to rely on this resource.

[00:46:40] Because even though there might be some difference of opinions on sort of how we are evaluated, thought I did this you know there's some sort of healthy conversation there that at its core folks believe these are the right practices for babies for toddlers and for for preschoolers as you look at the rating summary this gives you a breakdown of kind of a couple of key key elements here so we see 99% of sites are either meets or exceeds expectations and so that is an improvement from last year as you look at the where we were 98 percent it is important to note that we

[00:47:18] have bigger buckets at this point in time so you'll see those points so there's a ton of variability right so you might have someone who ranges from 401 points to 698 points right in that kind of bucket so everybody gets a specific three three-digit score and then you have these sort of broader ratings we are extremely excited about those exceeds expectation those are national exemplars that is a very high bar to meet and as we said before this is a national tool not a Virginia tool so we know that and we are raising the floor and I'll talk a little bit more in a moment about how the team achieved

[00:47:52] this but we went from 51 sites in that need support category down to 25 this year so cutting that in half when we look at improvement this is a positive finding across the board I think if you were to ask where we'd like to see more movement we can talk a little bit about that but we'd like to see a little bit more improvement but we overall in addition to the ratings which again as I said before broad buckets we really care about what those three digit scores are and what we see is overall improvement in our average score we saw the sort of the greatest growth actually in family day homes they actually have sort of the

[00:48:31] lowest overall average but we saw significant growth there and we saw growth in schools we saw growth in childcare centers and we saw growth and family day home so we kind of again it's not just about the ratings but really looking specifically at you know how much programs are growing we also ask the team to look at new sites right sort of 200 more sites this year and to look at those averages and so you'll see again that those are slightly lower than the overall sites not not necessarily you know in that kind of need support range but still a place where we have to really be thinking about when we have

[00:49:09] new programs on how do we support them at the outset we have seen across the board curriculum is an option it's a way to earn 100 points if you're using a high-quality curriculum and while we started VQB 5 99% nearly all of our Head Start and VPI programs are using curriculum because it's a program requirement we saw really low numbers in family child care and child care and so we have worked very thoughtfully over the last few years while keeping curriculum into choice to approve a set of options as high-quality instructional material to make a free option.

[00:49:45] We did an RFP or an RFI, rather, and have identified STREAM in three, which is the state's open educational resource is free for programs, was piloted and built with family child care so it can be used in all settings, and that's how you help see pretty significant improvement in use of curriculum in child care and in family child care.

[00:50:06] And then the -- one of the primary goals of VQB5 beyond kind of trying to drive systematic improvement through the series of observations and very specific measurement use of curriculum is really saying how do we make sure that no matter where a family is in the state that they can choose quality.

[00:50:25] And so we have a really intensive focus on how do we raise the floor. We do that by prioritizing our resources towards those need support sites. This is a model that Assistant Superintendent Carol helped pilot in Louisiana and was incredibly successful, recognized nationally, and we've put in place here.

[00:50:44] So when we had the 50 -- the second we knew which 51 sites were in that need support category last year, Chris and the team went into action. We have quality consultants who went and met with them. This board said that we would have required improvement planning, so it's not a choice.

[00:51:01] You need to participate in this improvement planning. We didn't take anybody or threaten anybody's public dollars, just said you have to participate in improvement planning. We partnered with the Virginia Early Childhood Consultation, run by UVA, and we basically had -- and we let the -- we worked with the REDI Regents.

[00:51:17] We did a survey on what the kind of contextual needs of the programs were. We looked deeply at their data. We sent out the quality consultant to let them know what was occurring. And then, month after month, they were assigned coaches who worked with them to improve interactions, consider using curriculum for the first time and we were very excited to see that all 50 of those sites have moved out of either of the need support category so in one year kind of getting them to a place where there's higher quality interactions and more use of curriculum.

[00:51:51] Now we have another 25 sites that are in that category we would like there to be none and so we're really looking at two things right now how do we support those 25 sites this this This process has already begun for them this year, and really looking at the data as who is on the cusp, what happened to those 25 in that year.

[00:52:08] Nine, I think, of the 25 are new, so it's not entirely that these are new, but really looking at our data to say how do we raise that floor, and how do we provide some protective factors. So we do also allow coaching and prioritization for those folks that are just above that cutoff, and the goal being that we would prevent, and hopefully I'll be here next year presenting to this board, and that'll be a big zero in that category.

[00:52:32] So that's kind of a way that we're raising the floor. One of the things that we talked about in addition to kind of our, you know, this key priority of making sure that families can always choose quality is we also wanted to elevate the excellence and the improvement happening.

[00:52:50] And so this year, thanks to decisions made by this body, which put the kind of required us to create honor rolls in the guidelines, We announced the rollout of three honor rolls to elevate excellence, to recognize quality of infant-toddler interactions because there's such demand, and these are sort of the most expensive and sort of high-stakes classroom, and to motivate continual improvement.

[00:53:13] And this, in addition to the ratings and the scores, helps elevate the sector and inform parent choice. We have just under 500 sites on our honor roll. You'll see that centers, if you move to the next slide, you'll see that centers, family day homes and public schools are all represented in those in those program and we have an extraordinary number of sites 19 sites statewide that received all three honor rolls i will take a moment of privilege to recognize cecilia suarez who has been on our advisory committee i believe since the very beginning runs creative day learning in northern virginia does work in english and

[00:53:52] in Spanish and has many educators who do early childhood care and education in Spanish and really was very concerned, expressed very constructive feedback at an ECAC meeting a few years ago about BQB5, about whether this was too much for her educators and for her program, whether this could be fair and could work well in classrooms where languages other than English were being used and really sort of said, we have got to figure out how to make this work and put the charge in front of Chris and myself and the team and the Ready Regions and our partners.

[00:54:31] And I couldn't have been more pleased than last week to be able to announce that Cecilia earned improvements, highest of quality interactions, and overall excellence. And just this moment of going from somebody who had such great doubts and was really concerned about how do we do this well, right, how do we make sure this works for some of our most vulnerable kids and families to come full circle and to demonstrate all that improvement and ultimately excellence.

[00:54:57] I also include, and you're going to have to get out your reading glasses to see it, but I couldn't not put it out there, just the 101 sites that are receiving and exceeds expectation on this excellence, like this is extraordinary. These are high-quality interactions.

[00:55:16] These are programs in rural Virginia and urban Virginia, suburban Virginia, kind of in cities and in towns. These are well-known programs and unknown programs. We have family child care scoring very high and we have Head Start scoring very high.

[00:55:32] And I just want you to take a moment to look at the incredible sort of range and diversity of those programs. I hope that if there are superintendents or community leaders watching that they'll take a moment just to recognize excellence in our in our communities and it really is defy stereotypes we cannot judge these experiences based on the outside of the building or the funding source but truly kind of look at these exemplars this also means that there is excellence across the state and if you sort of folks are like how if i'm a brand new child care center owner or i'm

[00:56:07] a brand new teacher where would i go being able to sort of point to these 101 exemplars which is more than last year's of 79 is just incredible. As you move forward, you'll see that these are the, so hopefully you'll start to see these certificates and we've seen great postings on social media and other places across the state so far. I also really was struck by President Creasy's point about the long run and I just want to tell a little story for a moment. Last Friday, I received a call out of the blue from a Louisiana area code and

[00:56:44] was a child care center director in the Mississippi Delta area of Louisiana, a very historically underserved community. And after apologizing profusely for inadvertently mixing up numbers in her phone, she went on to tell me, you know, that she was so pleased with her program because they had finally earned sixes on class. So they had finally earned the kind of equivalent of exceeds expectation it's taken many years um but for a leader over a 10-year period to believe in

[00:57:19] this to in a in a in an area of the state where it's hard to find good k-12 teachers not to mention child care to survive this pandemic and serve as such an essential resource and the thing that she says to me after sort of saying how are you how are your kids is would you believe it i got sixes um and I'm so excited to be excellent and so I hope that you know you know as we look forward um the lasting impact of this um uh truly you know as if Louisiana is an example it you know truly can make a difference not only on the kids that you happen to benefit from uh quality last

[00:57:56] year but you know truly for for the next decade and just make sort of the the work and the decisions of this board, that much more important, and we're going to be there to support the next decade and to use information to continually improve the system because we now have VA Connects. And so, as a reminder, we've got three systems supported in large part by UVA through another kind of research policy partnership. We've got VALS, which covers language and literacy. We've got Virginia Kindergarten Readiness Program, or VKRP, which is school readiness for every single public kindergartner in the state as well as for a significant subset

[00:58:36] of three and four year olds and we have Blink B5 which captures that data down to the classroom level thanks to the incredible work of our was supported by our ready regions and partners in the field but of our team and UVA we rolled out fully rolled out VA connects this year which kind of connects all these systems on the back end there were some challenges around the complexity the beginning and so huge thanks to the field for your patience over the course of this late summer and fall but it really helps us connect sort of experiences to longitudinal outcomes so now I can sort of tell you well this kid

[00:59:15] was funded with this program and then this is how this kid did in third grade but I don't know actually what that kid experienced and the classroom not the funding source is the greatest point of variability so if you go to the next slide and you some of you may have seen this Grace probably saw this years ago excuse me President Chrissy probably saw this years ago and when it was a pipe drain but the idea is we now understand which kids are in which classroom we know how those classrooms score on quality we know the we know the credential of the teacher the curriculum use the compensation and thanks to smart probabilistic matching we can then once that kid enters VKRP we can sort of

[00:59:53] assign that kid or kind of connect that kid with their state testing identifier and then we can track them all the way through even into our longitudinal data system which captures college, career, and beyond. And so what it means is you don't just have to take my word or sort of the national studies that suggest that interactions matter for kids learning. We will be able over the next two decades to demonstrate that at a very large scale and we think that this is the nation-leading kind of early childhood integrated data system because it's the only one that's actually connected to a live measure of what kids are experiencing not just

[01:00:30] how they're funded or where they might be served so very very exciting um kind of multi-year work on behalf of our our partners and i'll give you an example of how we're even beginning to use this data on the um the next slide so when we asked our folks in preparation for the deep dives I should note the deep dives are two hours and 70 slides, which Chris does rinse and repeat nine times.

[01:00:56] Our internal deep dive was upwards of 180 slides. So this is all a paring down. But one of the things that really stuck out for me when we reviewed that as a team is we were sort of really looking at how do you think I'd improve it. And what this slide shows you is you have to think of this very differently.

[01:01:15] This is fall to spring data. So this is looking at the fall of 2024 and the spring of 2025. The right bar is schools, right? And so what that is saying is that in the classrooms, if you look at who the teacher was in the fall and who the teacher was in the spring, 95% of the time, it's the same teacher, right?

[01:01:35] So as you think about improvement, you're thinking about-- and some of those teachers will leave over the summer, but like you are thinking about partnering with schools to build systems that are sort of focused on enhancing and supporting learning, right? You're going to have the same educators. In

sharp contrast, in childcare between the fall and the spring, so this is not year-over-year turnover, this is literally within six months, you see 31% of those teachers are leaving.

[01:02:01] And so when we think about our need support sites, when we think about improvement, we have to really be thinking about who is entering this workforce, right? Because it's not going to be about the same repeated sort of enhanced professional development or technical assistance. It's going to look very different. This also contrasts with family child care, where we know on average our child care leaders and educators are there for eight, nine, ten years, right?

[01:02:23] And so this really sort of -- this data is so essential. If you were to say, "Jenna, how will you improve experiences across the board?" You have to use this data, because it shows you, even in this six-month snapshot of last year, taking a one-size-fits-all approach to improvement -- oh, excuse me -- will not work, right?

[01:02:41] Because I can -- I'm going to work with that family child care educator differently, because I know she's going to be there in five years, in probably ten years, and I'm going to think differently about how I support this child care educator. But as we do with VECC, we're going to also think about the leader, because the leader will be there in six months, and that particular educator might not be.

[01:02:59] And that was a really sort of those types of insight are only made possible by having this type of data and being able to kind of really work with our improvement partners, with our sites themselves, with school divisions, with Head Start grantees, to say you have to look at your data.

[01:03:15] This isn't about just randomly picking a professional development and putting it out there. It is about looking at your specific data on how you're gonna improve and really thinking about each of those individual classrooms. And last but not least, we also want, particularly for our three and four year olds, to kind of understand their direct relationship.

[01:03:32] And so we now, that we have vowels in place, we have that rigorous language and literacy screener, we're able to look at for roughly the 35,000 kids We do have outcomes data on for three- and four-year-olds, how to look at all three elements, curriculum, interactions, and kids' growth from fall to spring.

[01:03:51] And so that'll be sort of a new focus that was only made possible by the implementation of VALS and VA Connects in the last year. So with that, I just wanted to highlight again that from here, we go out, we do, we've done two, Two of the right two, but who's counting?

[01:04:09] We have seven more deep dives to do, and then we will be coming back to this body as we are continually analyzing this data and saying, here are the things that we think are necessary to continue to drive improvement as we bring the guidelines back to you for 25, 26 and beyond, for 26, 27 and beyond.

[01:04:30] Thank you very much. Let me pause and see what questions you might have. Any questions, comments? Dr. Northern? awesome, awesome job. I am so excited that, I mean, we don't know this, like one-third of teachers and child care centers are leaving within the school year. Holy cow, that is like, and we don't, we don't have that data anywhere else, like, you know what I mean, like the fact that, that you know this is just like amazing, and the fact that what you're going to continue to uncover by linking these

[01:05:07] data sets, it's really exciting. I forgot to note, it's on the slide, but I've got to note, and that teachers who stayed scored on average higher in class right so we can already begin to connect you know beyond knowing instinctively that it's not a good thing to leave within the school year that we have actual

data that shows that does have a negative impact on kids yeah exactly so my comment is I'm just really excited about the linking of the data and the fact that you can uncover these patterns because you're exactly right those knowing the issues exactly lead you to be able to keep pushing you know and improving and improving improving I mean you know

[01:05:42] i was a little concerned before about like having such a high percentage i'm like okay that's 99 obviously we want it to be 100 but at the same time we want to hold the bar right up and so this tells me that we can very consciously um and strategically know how to continue to raise the floor when we have the data that are pointing out the weaknesses um and and yeah because i i get that we want 100 but we also want 100 to actually be meaningful you know so folks can really trust that number and this tells me that um that we're going to be able to keep doing that so so thank

[01:06:18] you for all the hard work honestly it's it's very exciting uh for us as a and you're right like uh just underscored what the superintendent shared at my travels everybody's talking about virginia's and what we're doing in early childhood so thank you for you and your team thank you and i think we We'll come back, and I think we want to sort of think through, you know, how do you have folks meeting expectations, right, but then also how are we really driving improvement?

[01:06:45] I will say sort of the improvement honor roll, which basically takes mathematically what is the improvement and sort of takes the 10 percent has been -- has really sort of provoked some conversation in the field, which we think is important in terms of supporting improvement. We also know folks are really sort of have feelings around some of those -- those places where it goes from kind of meets expectations to exceeds expectations.

[01:07:06] We also know that the overall averages were improvement, but we also know it's not quite as much improvement as we want to see. So 53% of sites, their numerical score was higher. Small number was exactly the same, and 47% were lower. And we would like to see more sort of improvement in terms of the proportion of sites.

[01:07:25] And so we will come back to you. This is what we're analyzing right now is really trying to figure out how do you get so every site is improving, right, rather than sort of some sites making larger improvements that then lead to kind of the overall average. And that, I think, will potentially come back with sort of some shifts this year to think about, you know, do we need additional buckets?

[01:07:46] How do we think about our incentives to make sure that everybody is improving? But the key part is even though it's saying that 99% of sites are meeting those expectations, we have that more precise data, that three-digit score that allows us then to kind of come back to you all and say, hey, here are the shifts to kind of further and send improvement, further and send excellence, sort of better delineate for families.

[01:08:10] So that's that is our current work right now. Is there a particular criterion that they're struggling with? I know that there are so many dimensions on those. So it's it's largely comes down to instruction. And so that's part of. So there's, you know, the it's not it's class is not tied to any particular curriculum or kind of, you know, but so it's kind of called engage.

[01:08:32] It's part of the infant piece, so the infant is using language, right, and kind of constantly talking with children, thinking about that work. For toddlers, it's called engaged support for learning. And then in preschool, it's instructional support. And the example we give is, you know, and you start to see this, if you

look at the vows pre-K from last year, one of the areas in where kids are not making the most growth is expressive comprehension.

[01:08:58] And so class calls on asking how and why questions, building on the kid, prompting the kid to build. It's hard, right? I mean, if you're around a three-year-old, I find myself, I'm like, what color is this? Like, how many fingers, right? How old are you? And that is not getting kids to kind of think as critically, right?

[01:09:17] It's not kind of, you know, and we have to pause, right? Because sometimes they take a little while for their things to get out, and sometimes they're a little tangential. But that's a, to me, we're very close and we're doing some really important work with this, the preschool VKRP and VALS and VPI to start to connect.

[01:09:34] Like here, we are struggling a little bit on instruction. Curriculum is a big play, right? And we're going to sort of see, you know, it's one thing to say you're using curriculum. It's a whole other thing to use it kind of. It takes about two to three years, right, to fully implement that. And then to kind of connect it to if you want to see kids grow.

[01:09:51] like we're really good at helping kids identify letters and write their names by the end of the four year old year we are you know we can improve and how we really develop those critical thinking skills and do some of that concept development i think that that data that is starting to emerge miss northern as a kind of a trend there mr monk thank you first just awesome work i know this is not only showing impact now but we'll see the benefits of this long term so thank you for that And as a newer member, just trying to gain some context here, I noticed the approved curriculum,

[01:10:27] and it looks like most of the scores as they go into the site are 100, and you kind of hit it on your last answer there. Is that more of a checkbox of they've got this approved curriculum, or are they actually showing it in the visit? So it is a, right now, it's sort of, if you're using it in just one classroom, This board has agreed in last year's guidelines to sort of raise that bar in two years time to kind of all classrooms. The goal there is to kind of get is to encourage everybody to choose to use a curriculum. What we have found when you

[01:11:01] look at sort of the work and the research on it, it's very hard to, at scale, kind of evaluate how well they use curriculum. So you think of kind of curriculum as your more blunt measure and class as your more specific measure. And so what the hope and of the design of the system is that 100 points gets you to sort of begin to adopt it what we found and the reason that we added curriculum in here in virginia is because in louisiana we were using class alone for a couple of years and child care folks started coming to us and saying i can't move on instructional support like my teachers can't make it up every day and we're like we should start using curriculum and like well you can you help us pay for it and

[01:11:38] we're like okay well this is clearly kind of this trajectory so rather than just require curriculum which sort of doesn't necessarily kind of you don't see it sort of things getting better we sort of say well we'll incent you to use curriculum and the goal is that as you use curriculum you're going to see those instruction scores go up and so my um and we'll see whether or not at some point we decide because everybody's using it it may not be as relevant to keep but it's helped go from 40 of family child care and child care using it upwards to 80 and i think we're going to start to see the differential being the interactions, not so much the curriculum.

[01:12:16] - And just follow up on the curriculum component there. I know it says approved curriculum. What is the, obviously we want it to be high quality, but knowing that there's faith-based and you know, what does that look like in terms of getting your curriculum approved?

[01:12:32] - Yeah, so we will review all curriculum, which was something that is a little different from how it works in K-12 because of the history of early childhood. We have had, for example, school divisions make serious investments in curriculum because there weren't a lot of commercial products available.

[01:12:47] We have some open educational resources. So for the last five years, you've submitted your curriculum to us, even if it was homemade, and we have reviewed it in line with our early learning development standards as well as some kind of nationally accepted criteria on quality.

[01:13:03] And so we have a faith-based option that is being used. We have some school division-created resources. have some of the more kind of traditionally well-known kind of creative curriculum. And then we have Stream in 3, which is our open educational resource. Stream in 3 is our most frequently used because it's free or low cost. We also, my experience in Louisiana around supporting use of curriculum is, and kind of going back to the stat about 31% of teachers leaving, what you're really trying to do is not only think about kind of a one-time training for this teacher, but

[01:13:38] institutionalize that curriculum within the ecosystem of the center right and so by having an open educational resource where anybody can offer pd on and it's not proprietary it is our hope that we can kind of build it into the system so when you're the assistant teacher you're learning from the lead teacher right if you're you know it's kind of everybody in that program is using it realistically that's going to take you know three to five five years but we did want to say you know rather than say you have to purchase an appropriate if you've got something great and you're providing you know and it's meeting these standards then that's gonna and you'll see if you go you can actually go i should say this to you remember northern you can go to

[01:14:14] our website you can click data download and you get it all so you can look at the top 101 in the state and you can look at what curriculum we're using and it's it's not all the same right there's various ones being used in different ways but you'll see that um you know our highest scoring school is in a really rural community right and you know and then we have that right next to you you know, schools from Fairfax and Northern Virginia, right?

[01:14:36] So it's really -- it's a -- the data even on curriculum shows that it needs to be of a certain quality, but we shouldn't be necessarily pushing one resource for everybody and that it is important if you've developed an owner, if your faith-based values are key to you and you can meet the quality criteria, we should be supporting that.

[01:14:55] You -- and we kind of alluded to this, but tracking, and you've done some of that data set here, but what ability do we have to track, you know, if a student was in a meets expectation or exceeds expectation, grade 3 you mentioned long term how can we track that student if is that possible yes we do now this has been a work in progress and I'll try to do the high level answer but basically we created something called classroom lists and we worked with providers you know to sort of do so that parents were aware and could you know opt in or opt out and then what we knew from years and years of doing PALS is that we can get that information it's basically five fields about the children the

[01:15:34] child and then very safely match it on the back end with their state testing identifier the second they pop up at public school so what it means is basically and this is why we had some of the challenges via connex this fall as these kids are coming in we're running numbers to sort of see okay were you ever in early childhood and then we're linking those records so that at some point we'll be able to sort of look back and say as a baby they were in a you know meets expectation as toddler they were here they were you know and sort of all the way through these this is like the first year that finally we have these kids and sort of begin to do this so kind of the clock

[01:16:09] starts now um but yes mr monk will be able to do that and when we roll out attendance tracking uh in december of this year we'll actually be able to understand how much of the service did they get what was the quality measurement you know what played in we might find that interaction scores don't matter if you're only there 50 of the time right and so kind of being able to kind of take all that data that the biggest challenge and and again uh uh president christine knows this better than anyone everybody thought we were totally bananas we proposed this you know we began building the data system before even the law had passed but we will see over time that we believe it will pay

[01:16:45] off for the commonwealth other questions or comments so of course i have lots uh but first i really just want to say um you know one of the things to respond to dr northern about you know that that that 31 percent leaving one of the things that we looked at gosh jenna how long ago was it when we talked about um you know salaries and how salaries even regionally were impacting

[01:17:17] um and how salaries um or pay scales um you know between different types of providers were really impacting where um the workforce was sort of shifting i think that would be an interesting maybe follow-up presentation if we're continuing. I should note the other version of that slide has the comp for those two levels. So the for the child care teachers is about $17 an hour for the school-based teachers at 28 to 32. Yeah so I think maybe a really awesome follow-up presentation would be to talk about you know what that those differences look like regionally within the

[01:17:56] different types of providers because I think that just re-ups the the immediacy of all of it for us just so that we're really connecting all of the dots and pulling it all together. I think it would be also interesting to see that maybe you know perhaps our highest honor rollies maybe aren't the highest paid. You know I think that's a lot of very interesting data too that that the field would really like to see, as well as those of us sitting here. So that would be one point that I'd

[01:18:27] like to make. The second is, I'm really, really, really harping in my own mind on this development and continued support of our instructional leadership. So as you talked about, leaders and centers being very, or being our most lasting piece of the puzzle within each individual provider site, you know, I think it's imperative that we hone in very specifically, very intently,

[01:19:00] and very strategically to those leaders and how they are able to provide that continuity when perhaps there may not be considering some turnover. I think that's a lesson that K-12 needs to learn frankly um because i think that we have um we've really really really got to focus on how we continue to support principals in school principals assistant principals in school buildings across the commonwealth to continue to do the work of that instructional leadership how are we

[01:19:37] equipping them to be the best instructional leader to then help those teachers in classrooms that maybe you know really do need that instructional support whether it be from a pedagogical standpoint or from just a practical you know this is this is how we operate in a school building type type

situation so I think learn we we have a lot to learn in k-12 from our early childhood system and I really I don't I really hope that our k-12 partners are listening

[01:20:12] to this because I do think that it it's going to be a dramatic transfer transformation of our holistic educational system if we are truly able to connect those dots between early childhood and k-12 and keep them strongly connected and you know you guys have done a great job of doing that reaching out and holding hands when people are probably trying to let go of your hands but I continue to encourage you all. Not optional. We don't let go of your hands. Right. No, and I'm talking about the connection between early childhood and K-12 hand-holding because it is

[01:20:51] crucial to continued development and identification. And so in the future, as we continue to get more data and information from you, another thing that I think that we would like to see is how are we using this system to also support educators in those early childhood classrooms in that identification of special education and needs there. So another follow-up presentation that I know would be really informative to the board would be around consistency in identification.

[01:21:26] So our, you know, I had a conversation with Clark Anders the other day, and he said, you know grace we have a lot of of our students at our center that are then going into other divisions you're not all the same school division and we're not seeing consistency and identification you know what we're seeing in an early childhood classroom identifying talking to parents about is not getting connected when we send parents for identification purposes to the local public school

[01:22:00] So some kind of, you know, how are how are you all supporting those those early childhood educators in that identification and how to communicate that both to parents and then carrying that on to the school division?

[01:22:18] And then lastly, I just desperately, desperately hope that the media grasps on and does a major service to the families of the Commonwealth by raising the excellence that this system in the Commonwealth of Virginia, the North Star that you all are providing in this area of education, we absolutely have to elevate this in the media to be able to get this in the hands of parents

[01:22:54] and so I beg of our partners in the media to please please elevate this because it is crucial to the future of the Commonwealth of Virginia for parents to know the availability of these options for our youngest learners and for us to have the greatest state in the country so thank you so much for all the work that you all have done thank you president christie thank you sorry i got on my little soapbox excuse me um anyway we we are so appreciative of the work that you all have done

[01:23:30] and know that it continues and so we we will continue to thank you for that we will we will be back with more data and uh shifts on how we can continue to improve the system together thank you all very much thank you um does anybody need a quick break um let's do that and we'll be back

[01:23:47] in five minutes please we are back and we are going with um presentation b on the technical

[01:39:47] advisory council uh are you starting us off i'm kicking us off wonderful so um thank you board members good morning and so i am excited today to talk about our uh advisors that we have our technical advisory council that really supports us with all things assessment related and with me Today, I have Dr. Mary Ann Perry, who's going to share the outcomes of our last TAC convening

[01:40:19] and give an overview of our advisory council and their purpose. Good morning, everyone. It's good to be back and to see you all again. So I'm here today to talk about the-- we call it the TAC, the Technical Advisory Council.

[01:40:38] And I think it's important for everybody to understand is that when we're creating assessments, working on accountability systems in this state, in any state, We have outside experts come in to actually advise us on the technical issues, review what we're doing. There are times you need to check the vendor and see if what they're doing makes sense.

[01:40:57] So we bring in these outside experts. So we can do anything from assessment design, development, implementation. Most recently, we've been spending a lot of time on standard setting and cut scores. We also talk about scaling and equating growth models, item banks, new assessment items, automated scoring, test security there's all kinds of technical aspects that we can talk about and we have folks with various expertise to come in so I just serve as your facilitator I you know me from being involved in the standard setting but my background is as a psychometrician and I serve on six other state tax the other

[01:41:35] thing tax do is they bring in experience from other states we can say hey Florida's tried this have you thought about doing something this way so we bring that in. So Dr. Suzanne Lane is, I think she's been on 10, or it's on 10 TACs right now, but she just retired from the University of Pittsburgh, and she's been on your TAC for a little while. Dr. Denny Way has also been on your TAC for a while. He started out his life as a vendor psychometrician, working at Pearson, and I worked with him at ETS, and he recently retired from the College Board so he's worked on state assessment SAT we also brought in

[01:42:15] we sort of reconstituted your tack to bring in some new members and focus on the expertise of where we saw what we would need in the future so the first is dr. Molly Faulkner bond she is an expert on multilingual learners she got her PhD University of Massachusetts in psychometrics and one of the reasons we want to bring her on is she's also a parent of elementary school kids in Virginia public schools.

[01:42:41] So she has a very personal investment for making sure we're doing everything right with accountability and assessment. And finally, we brought on Vince Burgess, who recently retired as the assistant superintendent in Florida. So he'd been there for 20 years working on their assessment and accountability system. So he stood up, I want to say, three different systems in that 20 years. So he's seen those kinds of transitions. He's worked with the federal government to get approvals he's done all of that he started but before that he was a mathematics teacher and prior to that he was a Navy pilot so what we're

[01:43:20] really looking to do is provide these expert guidance recommendations oftentimes we're reviewing things that happened in the past but we're looking to inform how should we do that better in the future so we just met early this month and you can see we had the four TAC members I facilitated we had four people from our Department of Ed staff and we had some folks from the vendors and I do have to say the the TAC to echo something that was said earlier this morning that the TAC said this was one of the most collaborative meetings they've had in the last three or four years so they're really excited to see the direction that Virginia is going so the first thing we talked about was going over the whole

[01:43:58] standard setting everything you've heard about that's happened to set the cut scores we have a technical report that the TAC reviewed and made some comments on but overall they were very impressed that this was clearly a valid and reliable method they actually recommended continuing with id matching

whenever possible they really liked the way we used nape and incorporated nape into the the standard setting process uh so gave us some kudos on that um and again as we said looking forward because we know we've got standard settings coming up in our future we'll have more performance levels to

[01:44:34] set in other subjects um they really liked the inclusion of community members and said let's keep doing that um again id matching whenever possible and the only other change they recommended was we brought all of our committees in and had them on one group the whole time a big u shape and oftentimes in standard setting we'll divide people into smaller tables so they can have really rich discussions and then they report out to each other so the attack recommended that we consider doing that next time phased in um so to be very honest the the first reaction of being phased in

[01:45:09] was not positive because across the country we've seen this not work. People lose the political will to keep phasing things in over time. So the recommendation is keep the phase in as short as possible. As much as we've got current policy makers, we want to keep that phased in. So we talked a lot about when do we start and because of the accountability system and the fact that we have fall testers that go into the accountability system, the recommendation was think about this year as a prep year think about this year as a communication year got a lot of ideas about how to get information out to the public to the schools to help

[01:45:48] them prepare for the new cut scores but to really think about fall of 26 is maybe where we would put in the new cut scores we have a full year in front of us we talked about some of the other policies that are affected by the new cut scores such as the local validated credit where right now it says if a student earns at least a 375 and that may not make sense in a couple of years.

[01:46:13] So their recommendation is to start thinking about things as within an X number of points. As we know right now we don't have cut scores set up 400 at every single grade so not so saying with 375 doesn't make sense but saying within 25 points of the cut score could make sense. So we have what we call the standard error of measurement which is sort of the variability around any score you get. So you can put a little confidence interval around that and say you have to score within the confidence interval is the idea behind that.

[01:46:45] The other thing that came up, this wasn't actually on our agenda. We went off on a tangent here, but it's important. It was we got talking about the fact that Virginia allows retakes. And while that's generally a good thing, the concern is in practice sometimes people will have everybody who isn't proficient retake the test the next day.

[01:47:03] And for some kids, that's going to be a waste of time. If you're scoring again within that confidence interval, sure, take it again the next day. But if you're somebody who's scoring 100 points below proficiency, taking the test the next day is not going to raise your score by over 100 points. So it really said, let's spend some time doing some communication to the public about, or to our educators, to our school administrators, about when it makes sense to do a retake.

[01:47:28] And as we learn of effective professional development that can help, the training that will help the kids, things that actually can make a difference, let's get that information out to schools so they can say, When does it make sense to retest? And when are we just torturing our students?

[01:47:46] So the next thing we looked at is the entire item bank. And I should say at this point that we are-- we keep our meetings confidential. We keep our meetings secure, partially because we do things like

this next topic where we're actually looking at live items.

[01:48:07] So we want to make sure that things are-- that stay in the room and don't end up on Twitter or X. So we looked at the health of the item bank and said, OK, We've just made a pretty big change in terms of raising the proficiency and raising expectations.

[01:48:24] And we've talked about this before. Amber, you've pointed this out a couple of times, that we need to raise the rigor of the items. And we've been working on that, but we looked at the health of the item bank and said, you know, we really still need to keep working on getting more advanced items into the bank. So Pearson's made some progress.

[01:48:40] We kept looking at that needs to go forward. We also want to add a process to Pearson's approach where they actually have their item writers say what they're targeting in terms of the cognitive complexity. Is this item intended to assess proficient or advanced skills?

[01:48:58] And then use that, compare that to the data later. Pearson did a nice job creating materials for the tech and it included sort of a heat map of where the items fall for each standard along the difficulty scale. And it was really an interesting visual that showed you that there really are some standards that you can only measure up to a certain point.

[01:49:20] You can't measure the most advanced thing on this standard because it's a fairly straightforward standard. On the flip side, there are some standards that are so complex you really can't get below basic items out of them. So we recommended is there a way to create this visual in a way that will help teachers, educators understand how the standards and difficulty kind of work together and complexity work together.

[01:49:44] spent a lot of time talking about the Integrated Reading and Writing Assessment, IRW. The TAC really does say it has a lot of value, but we're concerned that it doesn't seem to have a purpose right now. So where we ended up was the TAC recommended using the IRW scores in grades 5 and 8 as the readiness indicator. We've got the readiness piece, and Mark will talk about this later today, but we'll talk about the, if we use it as readiness, not is academic achievement it has some oomph it gives us a reason to go in and really think hard about improving our students writing but it's not going to

[01:50:22] be one more test that adds into achievement so it does mean we'll need to set cut scores so that we can add something in here this is a short test it's 21 points I believe so the tax as you can't put in four cut scores and 21 points but we can put into maximum of two cut scores to really kind of divide up some performance. High school we spent a lot of time comparing the high school IRW to the end of course writing and the tax final recommendation is they said you know let's let's just stick with EOC writing it doesn't make sense to have both and the EOC writing gives more

[01:50:58] information because it's a longer test it has a higher degree of reliability and instead Pearson's done some work creating these of these IRW prompts in high school let's just give them to the schools and say here use this formatively in your classroom thank you Dr. Perry so next steps we so typically our TAC is five members and as you saw we have four so we will be adding one additional TAC member and we meet with TAC so we it's October we met and then we'll meet again in March but we can call on our TAC members anytime we need them so while it looks like the meetings are far apart

[01:51:37] we can actually they're a resource for us to pull on anytime we need support with assessments and so um so with that we'll end it there and open the floor up for questions are there any questions here

dr northern the integrated reading writing as a readiness indicator you said that we'll get that that's that was my biggest question we'll get that in a later session today you'll get a little bit more information um through uh mr jennings presentation when we talk about updates to our essa state plan okay and on the additional tac member i don't know

[01:52:15] if you've got names and i'm not going to give you names but i would say uh encourage you to look at curriculum associates um nwa and the center for assessment they're they're where a lot of people are pulling folks from yeah yes definitely yes other questions or comments thank you okay thank

[01:52:38] you i believe and so item c thank you dr perry thank you dr perry okay i'm ready yes all right

[01:53:16] come on up doc dr ballard so our next presentation is updates on school supports and so you'll see that we have the slide deck posted and and if we go to slide 2 for the last few months I've been coming to the board sharing updates on how we are reimagining statewide support for school improvement in August i talked about how we are grounding our work in data and so i am excited when we can bring the

[01:53:51] accountability results to you and really talk about the data and how we're targeting supports for schools we even started sharing some of the projected impact data for schools and divisions which we're going to use to help target support we talked about the customized support and how we're really looking to create these sustainable structures at the september board meeting we discussed the organizational structure and funding and so we talked about how we the we're undergoing this reorg and how we're hiring additional staff to meet specific needs and i am

[01:54:28] super excited we have been interviewing for the middle school math specialist and i mean i just want everyone who applied to hire them they're just so we have some great math people across our state and then um and we have about over 60 applications right now that we're about to start screening for our regional student support specialist positions and so i'm just really really excited with bringing on additional staff to help build our capacity and and extend our support across the state and we also talked about some some strategic funding opportunities and

[01:55:04] just how we are awarding doing grants a little differently now and so today in advance of releasing accountability results we are going to focus on how we are going to support these schools that will be identified through the accountability system and so if we go to slide three one of the things anytime you're working um with the accountability system and there are certain federal requirements and state requirements it can feel like compliance like we're just checking the box we're going to do a needs assessment check the box we're going to fill out an application check

[01:55:41] the box and that's not what we want to do now we know that we have to do certain things to move students forward and to ensure that we are meeting those requirements defined by the state and federal government but we also want to do it in a very intentional way so that it it's not a compliance driven tool but something that's really used to move things forward so what you'll see in this presentation is that we are revising the needs assessment and that whole process we are revising the monitoring process and so any school division in any school that was previously identified for comprehensive

[01:56:18] support and improvement they can't just dust off their old plan and we're just going to make some tweaks and resubmit because we are truly changing the process to to focus more so we're not focusing on everything where you got identified for this let's dig deep into why you got identified for this and what's the specific data points and and really focusing on those data cycles how often are you looking

at your student data and monitoring looking at those 30 60 90 day cycles so we are super excited you know that that we're gonna start to

[01:56:54] do more of that. On slide four, what you'll see is the the Virginia schools performance and support framework and this is what's used to identify these schools and there's been a lot of work done to ensure that we are aligning the performance categories with federal identification because it can be confusing to the public if there's a comp a school that's been identified for comprehensive support and improvement but has a distinguished status as a performance category and so what mr. Jennings and his team that what they

[01:57:30] have done is really worked hard to ensure that the newly identified comprehensive support and improvement schools they will be in the needs intensive support category so when we talk about what supports are available for the needs intensive support schools a lot of that is going to fall under that see it those supports for CSI schools and then also for the targeted support and improvement schools these schools are going to fall under the on track off track or needs intensive support so once again when we look at what are the supports that are going to be available for needs intensive support schools a lot of it is going to align to comprehensive support and targeted

[01:58:06] support to those supports and so that tight alignment is so critical on slide five it's just a high-level overview of how schools are identified and this you'll get into way more detail about this once all results are released so we're really just focusing on we're preparing for that release because as soon as everything is made public we are ready to start to kick off all the support another big part so when we go to slide 6 is our memorandum of understanding school divisions one of the first meetings I was in when we

[01:58:45] started when I came here was looking at these MOU school divisions how long some of them have been identified as MOU looking at the MOUs to see are they ever even able to get out of mou status and what kind of supports could we provide them and so the great thing is under the our consolidated plan so it's very clear that if 40 of the schools in your division are identified for comprehensive support and improvement or additional targeted support and improvement you will be a mou school division if 10 or more schools are identified for

[01:59:19] comprehensive support and improvement you will be a mou school division and there are certain requirements that come with that such as the division level academic and resource allocation review and so that is something once these results are released and we identify those school divisions we will work with them throughout this process because the goal is not to keep you in mou forever we want to make sure that there is a clear exit strategy and that it makes sense for your school division on slide seven what you see are some of the resources that will be

[01:59:59] shared very soon we are so thankful to work with our partners at waypoint to take all of this federal and state compliance driven language and to break it into language that's parent friendly and teacher friendly and principal friendly and so what school divisions and this will be available they'll get customizable slide decks where they can drop in their own school's data and they can talk through with their communities that's this accountability and the difference between accountability and accreditation because there's still a lot of confusion in the field

[02:00:34] about that and they'll also be able to you know really go through why did we get identified and then what's the the plan to so that we're not going to continue to be identified so there'll be some very clear

resources for school leaders so in our listening sessions we've been hearing from principals a lot that they want resources they they want the state to send them resources because they don't always get all the resources that are coming out of the state so we are going to make sure that they receive these resources and guides for families so when a school is identified as comprehensive support and improvement or targeted support and improvement what does that

[02:01:12] mean for a parent. What supports are available to you as a parent? So we want to make sure that is clear and it's ready to go as soon as those as the schools are identified. Slide eight so these are the two documents that define those requirements so it's our ESSA consolidated plan and our standards of accreditation. Mr Jennings he's going to get up later today and talk about some revisions that we are that we want to start doing to our ESSA consolidated state plan so that there can be more flexibility with school improvement and so that it doesn't feel so compliance focus

[02:01:51] because when you look at our s estate plan there's things like well you have to create the template which is yes we have to create the template but does that need to be in the s estate plan so it's little things like that that we're going to start to look into and how we can do some things differently slide nine details all of the requirements like what are the must do's and who's required to monitor is this a Department of Education do we need to go out to your school is this a division that you need to monitor and so this is just a snapshot of what's required by for comprehensive support

[02:02:28] improvement schools targeted support improvement schools and additional targeted support and improvement schools and once again a lot of these schools are your needs intensive schools and so if you are identified as needs intensive a lot of this is going to apply to you and so on slide 10 this is where the office of school improvement under Dr. Ballard is really going to come into play because they are working to coordinate this cross-divisional support it's not just his office that's leading the school improvement work they are the

[02:03:05] point they are the ones who are going to be working with the principals and the assistant principals and the division leaders but they are going to make sure that our that across the board if a if a school needs help with attendance we have people at the state who can help with that if a school needs help with their students with disabilities we have people at the state that can help with that so they are going to really work in depth with the leaders to ensure that systemic planning and sustainable planning is happening and that the supports are there for them so I'm going to call Mr. Ballard Dr. Ballard up to

[02:03:42] just talk a little bit about how they're going to do that through these needs assessment supports plan resource reviews plan approval and monitoring Thank You Deputy Superintendent Dwyer Booker Dwyer to President Creasy members of the board State Superintendent Gullickson good morning I'm glad to be with you all this morning so on slot 10 the office of school improvement as As Deputy Superintendent Booker Dwyer just mentioned, provides guidance, technical assistance, and support to divisions and schools identified for improvement throughout the Commonwealth.

[02:04:20] Once schools are identified, as she's mentioned, OSI is looking forward to providing the technical assistance and coaching support through a variety of modalities to include virtual and in-person trainings and learning experiences, lunch and learn offerings, office hours, coordinating even individualized regional support and convening meetings as well with division OSQ contacts, principals, and other division and school leaders as she just briefly mentioned.

[02:04:46] So using a continuous improvement cycle that starts with building a team that is composed of diverse stakeholders who will support the work of improvement, OSI will be coming alongside divisions and standing shoulder to shoulder with school leaders to provide coach support and technical assistance when they are conducting their needs assessments which is going to be focused on factors that lead to schools or school identification status in the new support performance and support framework the school performance I'm sorry and support framework so

[02:05:21] information and findings from this needs assessment will be instrumental in the development of their multi-year school and or division support plan that was just referenced which will include information regarding contributing factors that are related to those indicators around mastery readiness and growth measurable goals aid in the identification of evidence-based interventions and and outline strategies and action steps that will be taken to make progress and to reach the desired student improvement goals or outcomes that we're striving to see. In addition, OSQ will be supporting schools with their resource review

[02:06:01] and effective resource distribution around their school and across the school division. Now, upon completion and approval of the plans, as schools and divisions transition to implementation and monitoring, OSI will leverage working, as Ms. Booker-Dwyer mentioned, across the agency more closely and collaboratively with our colleagues from other offices who are the subject matter experts as part of the review process and to support more focused and systematic improvement efforts.

[02:06:36] And so she just mentioned a couple of examples, but that is precisely right. If we had a school or division whose plan is focused on the acquisition, usage, or professional development around HQIM, OSI would actually take that cross-departmental approach. We would be working with our teaching and learning and instructional team If it was around chronic absenteeism, special education, we would be doing the same thing, if you will, with the Office of Behavioral Health and Student Safety, and likewise with the Office of Special Education Instructional Services and Supports.

[02:07:09] And so we'll transition to slide, next slide at this point, slide 11. Okay, here we go. And so as it relates to, I'm sorry, follow along.

[02:07:25] So, the 2025-26 school improvement grant opportunity actually provides, I'm sorry, continued support to schools federally identified, as mentioned, for comprehensive support and improvement, targeted support and improvement, and additionally targeted and support and improvement.

[02:07:46] These funds that you see here must support the implementation of the school's multi-year support plan and provide assistance to ensure the implementation of appropriate supports and evidence-based intervention to address their federal identification.

[02:08:02] Specific school improvement grant funding considerations are based on the school's federal identification and the needs articulated in the submission of a complete school improvement grant application which will also accompany that uh include rather that multi-year support plan that's accompanied with a continued focus on systemic improvement these funds can be used to support implementation of interventions aimed at improving student outcomes and performance around examples such as you know professional professional learning experiences the acquisitions of math and learning coaches tutoring support attendance initiative community community engagement

[02:08:41] just to name a few things and so at this time I'm going to turn it over to Deputy Superintendent Booker Dwyer to talk a little bit more about the direct student services yes and we mentioned the direct student services grant at the last board meeting and we are are preparing to to have that released at the same time as our school improvement grant so that our school divisions can think holistically about all the supports that that they can use this funding for and we also just want to recognize from our general fund what's what's helping us do all this

[02:09:19] work we have that 1.9 million dollars that was appropriated to to us and that is very important to that's the engine that's allowing us to do all of this work with the with the team and so on slide 12 we know that there's all these plans and needs assessments that need to be completed but we these have to be living documents dynamic documents not just check the box type of things and so we're going to do some intensive support on how are you how are you

[02:09:54] developing your plan so that it fits the school context to ensure that you are ready for the interventions that you want to implement and to ensure that it matches what your data says so there's perceived need and the actual need and sometimes we think we need something but then as you unpack that data that's not really what you need and so it's going to be some very deep professional learning around that and we're encouraging leveraging the external partners I mean when we started in August with this school improvement series we brought in that partnership between Danville and the University of

[02:10:31] Virginia and how they work through their leadership to inform that the systemic improvement you heard earlier from Hopkins and from a different national expert series and so bringing in some of these national experts to support school improvement and they can leverage these funds to do that so we will encourage that and then with monitoring this will not be a check the box monitoring we're not going through classrooms with clipboards that is not what we're doing with the monitoring process now we will be in classrooms we do want to see teaching and learning in action but we want to ensure that there is clear outcomes that there is movement happening we should not wait until the

[02:11:11] state assessment data and then be surprised at the outcomes and so when we are crafting the needs assessment in the plant there needs to be clear benchmarks and that's what we're coming out to see how are you measuring your progress and if did you meet that benchmark if not why not and we're be looking at those benchmarks to see are are they are they right sized we don't want it too low we also don't want it so high that a student can't that it's not practical for your school so we're doing all of that you know and that'll be supported coordinated through dr ballard's team and so the

[02:11:46] next step so when you go to slide 13 i am excited that we are able to dig into this essa plan because that's just going to allow us to expand options to enforce school improvement And I'm also excited about the, about our EdFlex application, because not only will this allow us to expand the window upon, you know, how long you can expend these grant funds, but it also just gives so much more flexibility to school divisions with how they use the funds and not just school improvement grant funds, but title one funds.

[02:12:20] And so we are very excited about the upcoming, this upcoming submission of the application and this process to revise the ESSA plan. So with that, I will open the floor up to questions. Mr. Hanson.

[02:12:38] Thank you very much. Thank you for your time the other day as well. I appreciate all the great work that's going into this. Just on slide 11 with the breakdown of the grants, could you maybe just give me

a little bit of an illustration on how this is actually going to impact a district or a school?

[02:13:03] and then also there's going to be the process on some of the evaluation or understanding bringing some of the lessons learned from this and how those might be helpful in serving others along the way yes so I so we I'll give you a breakdown so the schools are identified based off of the the indicators in that school performance framework so let's say math performance that's that's a problem especially the middle school level and so when we look at their plan and the needs assessment we fully math needs to be on

[02:13:42] there and not just any math but middle school math and then even the math before that to make sure that your students are building up and then top on that we're gonna look at what curriculum are you using because we know that even if I mean the shortage of math teachers is not going to be fixed next school year this This is a longer term process and so we know that if you're using that high quality standards aligned curriculum you increase the likelihood of students achieving.

[02:14:10] And so we want to see what curriculum are you using and is it aligned to the standards. We want to see what are the professional learning experiences that you're doing. How many provisionally licensed teachers do you have in math and how can we support them in getting full credentials do you need math coaches or some of the math coaches and how can we partner so like I'm really excited at this idea of kind of regionalizing certain things where we can learn from across the region because middle school math is a challenge right now and in a lot of our divisions just looking at the data and we're also looking

[02:14:48] at the SOL data and those outcomes and what are those concepts that students are having difficulty with. And I'm so excited. Our math team, they are putting out the just-in-time quick checks for teachers right now. And we're hearing, getting a lot of great feedback about that. And what it is, it allows a teacher to use this document to quickly assess if there's a learning gap and then the strategies to address that gap. And so we're going to make sure that all those resources are available. And then we want to see what are the external partners that you're using and what experience do those external partners have in improving math performance.

[02:15:24] We know that, for instance, ZERN, we've been looking at data from that, and we've seen that that tutoring program has had some improvements. They help students improve in math. And so are you using high-quality vendors that actually have outcomes that connect to your students' context?

[02:15:42] So we're setting that foundation with the planning. And then when Dr. Ballard's team and he's taking other people from the department out into those schools, we want to make sure, we first want to look at the benchmark data. baseline was here you said by quarter one the kids will be here so let's see where they are and if they're not there why not we want to look in the classrooms and see how is the curriculum and instruction going we want to talk to students we want to talk to teachers we want to hear from the people on the ground is this plan being actualized or is this a plan that's sitting on the shelf and so it takes those foundational elements they have to be strong because then you

[02:16:21] can execute and hold people accountable when those foundational elements are strong so that's where we are right now so we are excited to get the you know the accountability results out there and to kick off all of this because dr ballard's team is ready we've been interviewing and hiring and bringing people on board but that's what it would look like and then they would have to fill out the application they would get receive the you know the school improvement grant funds and then there's a

fiscal monitoring piece and this is where we collaborate with budget to make sure you're spending down we don't want millions and millions of dollars returned to us that is something that we just have to stop in virginia and so we're going to make sure you're spending

[02:17:01] down if you're not why what's happening um and partly we have to make sure that our timing of releasing applications and funding is also um on time because sometimes it's us sometimes it's them so um so so that's what it looks like in a snapshot other questions dr northern um just two quick ones um since the school divisions who are in the i think you said in in need support category will be the only ones eligible for the grants is that correct well no so for the school

[02:17:38] improvement grant so they would be the only ones eligible for that grant but direct student services grant is open to all school divisions but it prioritizes school so when we're had the rubric there's extra weighting given to schools in that needs intensive support category and we we've been doing that with a lot of the grants that we put out because we recognize schools and that needs intensive support category they need a little bit more so we put a little bit of extra weighting in the grants for them okay and just just to note that sometimes they need help with the grant writing too right because sometimes if you're you know you don't

[02:18:14] have the capacity to write a good grant frankly so just just to make us aware of that and maybe sometimes they're not even applying for the grants and they're the ones most in need so just making sure that they're aware of these opportunities and encourage and help and support it and submitting those grants and the other thing is just on the substance side I've been encouraged I mean just it's not necessarily the curriculum piece it's the pedagogical piece right where we've seen kids just disengaged in classrooms I would just encourage us this teach like a champion uh book by doug lamov has been used just in a lot of places

[02:18:49] in a lot of different contexts to just learn how to engage kids better he's just got some very like concrete uh strategies like how to do a cold call for kids you know like that just can again it doesn't matter if you're in a math a science english doesn't matter if you're using a high quality curriculum or not it's just giving you some really good tools to make sure that kids are engaged in classrooms and teachers um the ones that i've interacted with who've used some of these strategies have been really grateful for them and really thought that they were impactful and he there's pretty there's free videos and books and resources on that website obviously i'd

[02:19:26] love to see us get some of those books out to teachers who are interested but there are plenty of free resources on on that site and i think it would be a good resource to add to your list of resources. Thank you for that. And your point about grant writing, we heard that from our listening sessions. And so we want to also just think differently. While we have people at the department who provide that technical assistance to help guide them, we're wondering, could there be a different approach? Does it have to be one person in central office responsible for it?

[02:19:57] There are teachers who want to build their skill set in grant writing. There are principals. There There's other people even in the community that may want to build their skill set. So we're just starting to look at some innovative ways to think outside of the box when it comes to grant writing and that we can train those people and build their skill set.

[02:20:16] Because if you know how to write grants, you know how to get money. So that's a great skill set to have. Other comments here? Mr. Monk. Thank you. And you're kind of dovetailing into what I'm

thinking about here. notice the funds available, right? But we also know that based upon previous presentations and information, the amount of dollars in education in Virginia is an all-time high, and so excited about that. But as part of your listening sessions and kind of the boots on the ground, what flexibility, and I know some federal can't do that, but from a state level, what flexibility

[02:20:53] are we looking at for maybe grant dollars or grants that have already been out there but maybe aren't working they're not having the intended impact and can we utilize those for that local division to to kind of as these groups are going in especially for these ones that need more support repurposing those dollars to help that local district definitely and this is where the that ed flex waiver comes in it'll help us with some of those federal grants and those restrictions you can't do this you can't do that so that waiver will help to release a lot of those restrictions um and give us that flexibility and then at the state level what number one you need

[02:21:33] the people at the state who can help and monitor so i'm just excited about the people that we're bringing on and the capacity that we're building and then also um you know i hear from divisions sometimes it's just you're you're asking for too much um it's it can be a lot to feel and you feel like what the state already has this data why are you asking me again for it when you're the one who identified me now i have to take this and put it back in an application so little things like that that can just kind of minimize the redundancy of information if we have the information we shouldn't ask school division for it because we already have it so it's little things like that i think that can go a long way in making people want to apply when they can just focus on the core content and not

[02:22:13] like repeating things that we already have at the state and it sounds like that will be a perfect kind of interlay with some of the grant the actual grant system that we talked about last month as well to make sure that our academic side is connecting with the operation side and talking each other so excited about that thanks for the work there superintendent gallickson yes um thank you president kuzzi and member monk we have been digging into every single state grant opportunity and really making sure what does it actually say because in some cases our application or

[02:22:53] requirements were really narrow and could be wider with additional guard rails for division and principal leaders to really stretch those dollars to work better on what their data was telling them and so have been going through every single grant across the whole agency so I'm excited about the momentum and we're continuing to take feedback on areas we can continue to simplify but stay really focused on that systems change and is it moving the needle for students I also

[02:23:24] want to recognize dr. Ballard and his team from the first month of my arrival they said hey we could be doing this a little bit differently and much better for students and so a few of these proposals seem like really small changes but the concept that the agency would now pursue this edflex to allow for a multi-year improvement grant i i need to pause so you can appreciate that historically the agency has done essentially nine month cycles where you don't even have a full school year to implement

[02:24:02] you're quickly turning around reporting data applying for the new grant cycle and that was one of the biggest points flagged for me early on in taking the helm at the agency by Dr. Ballard and his colleagues as well as the field of it's almost too difficult given windows and time and turnaround for us to really maximize those dollars and so one of the things we're really excited about as you saw on slide 13 is that under this edflex pursuit that we are

[02:24:37] looking at, we can work in partnership with the federal agency where we can actually stretch some of these subgrants. So we could look at a three-year grant cycle, for example, with an extra opt-in year because it's a maximum of four years. And when you think about transformational change, systems change, really being able to see impact like we did with Danville a few months ago, that is really exciting to make sure these dollars, every dollar is really working for students.

[02:25:07] The other part I want to emphasize that was flagged for me was the approach to these needs assessment and analysis on being grounded at data. I think there was good intention on the approach from before, but it really was a bit more of the one-size-fits-all.

[02:25:27] And as we know, these identifications on the federal level and our needs-intensive support have unique nuances for their own schools or communities. and so the team really helped champion this has to be a shift in how the agency partners and comes alongside and again appreciation for some of the prior conversations from our deputy superintendent on you know the weight of this work cannot just fall on Dr. Ballard and his team they're at this helm but that we need these subject matter experts from the agency great partnership and momentum

[02:26:06] from Deputy Superintendent Stacy Longus and others on really bridging finance and ops alongside divisions so that we can really maximize efficiency and effectiveness for students. And so I know these appear like quick bullets, but this is really substantive change grounded in what's best for students and the transformation we're hoping to see in partnership with the board.

[02:26:28] And so thank you to both of you for your leadership on this. It's no small feat. So I'm excited about the next steps. Other comments, Mr. Monk? I just want to thank you, Superintendent Gullickson, for sharing that as well. And just want to highlight, I think a lot of times we throw out these numbers, 24 million that can help.

[02:26:47] And when you're a classroom teacher, you're thinking, oh, well, that's somebody else will do that. That's the grant writer. And, well, we don't have one in our district. And so that's going to go to some other district. And, you know, you feel very isolated.

[02:26:59] And so the work that you're talking about of connecting the academic and the operations side is really going to be powerful for all districts, but I think especially those that are maybe smaller and more rural to be able to kind of see where those congruencies are lying and have access to dollars that are directly impacting students, but also hopefully freeing up time from those who are at the district level to really focus on what the implementation is.

[02:27:30] looks like of that grant as opposed to the minutia of the forms and the check boxes and all of those type of things so just yeoman's work and appreciate all that's done in the agency on that and I think that's a breath of fresh air for local school districts anybody else so before you guys finish I always want to let everybody else go before me unless I get too excited but one of things that i'd really like for us to try to weave in somewhere maybe within the grant system or how

[02:28:06] we are monitoring through the mou process i don't want to leave out the critical component of communication with parents so while we are focused very specifically on ensuring what's happening inside of the school building is being supported very deeply we cannot ignore the fact that student outcomes are directly related to how they are being supported at home as well so that collaboration between home and school we really need to come up with a strong component there on how you know

[02:28:43] not only are we supporting schools but we're also supporting families to support the whole community so I'd really like for us to think about how we can do that differently because I do think that gets us to that deeper level that that we want to achieve so that's the first piece the second piece is Dr. Ballard you may be better at providing us with this information just from your work closely with the MOU divisions but if there's a means by which the board can get some sort of historical

[02:29:18] presentation on those school divisions that currently sit in MOU status we do have a number of new board members that may have never seen that particular presentation to date and i do believe it's an important one to have i'd like for those divisions that are currently in status to be highlighted in such a way that we talk about the the length of time they have been in status but also the historical status so we have a number of those mou divisions that may

[02:29:52] have come out of stat that status for one reason or another at particular time periods and have ended have come back into status with an mou at other time periods so just that historical perspective on those divisions would be very helpful i think particularly as we get this new data that's coming out that's going to support you and your work the department's work and also the work of the the divisions moving themselves forward and what they need to accomplish in order to get themselves in better positions. I do think it's just kind of important for us to all be kind of on the same

[02:30:30] page and, you know, at baseline so that we know where forward is. And I know some of those things are going to change perhaps as the new data comes out, but I do think it's important to kind of show those shifts um for for uh the perspective that the board needs in making further decisions um anything else here thank you very much we appreciate it and dr ballard has all the history every time i talk to him it's a lesson yeah then we get into it so i i love it he has i know a

[02:31:08] wealth of knowledge yes so he can probably do that like off the cuff yeah on deck for next month sir Perfect. That would be wonderful. We always love seeing Dr. Ballard. Okay. Roadshow recap. Is that you again?

[02:31:24] I'm still here. Yes. Good, good, good. Do you need water? Nope. I am okay. This is all great stuff and it is all connected. And at the last board meeting, so this roadshow, we were very excited about this roadshow. We know that the board has taken some strong actions and some very needed actions to raise expectations through your approval of standards and you know we've redesigned the assessments to make sure that the test items are aligned to these standards and in September you approve

[02:31:57] the revised cut scores and on slide three you'll see the revised cut scores and we know that these scores are good for Virginia students because when you raise that expectation we know that number one Virginia teachers Virginia students they they rise up to that expectation they are prepared they have the skill set we know that right now it seems like there's a lot happening but we believe in our teachers and our principals and we know that they that they can do this to prepare our students for future

[02:32:35] opportunities not just in Virginia but across the nation and it also these higher expectations it really gives our the families clearer insight in in a more accurate picture of where their kid where their kid stands and how they can better support their kids through the schools and additional supports that will be provided and ultimately we want that the excellence in our public schools we want to continue that virginia has always been a top performing state and we just want to make sure that that that we don't lose any ground and then raising these

[02:33:11] expectations, it's good for Virginia. I mean, we are aligning to national benchmarks. You heard the superintendent talk about how states are backing out. They're lowering the bar while Virginia is moving forward. And then it just makes sure that our state stays competitive.

[02:33:31] We want the stronger workforce. We want that talent pipeline. And we want to be able to compete economically with other states and countries and we are very clear that these increased expectations require strong and strategic support and implementation so at that September board meeting we shared some recommendations with you regarding the implementation of these cut scores we provided recommendations around high school seniors so those graduating in class of 2026 to maintain that 400 proficient cut scores we talked about a multi-year implementation

[02:34:10] approach adding this new approaching performance level revising score reports for parents and i'm providing some targeted professional learning we did not want to propose anything for approval until we heard from our stakeholders the people who were going to it was going to impact the most so immediately after that board meeting i was in the hallway um scheduling meetings uh to to kick off this road show and when you look on on the next slide what you'll see is that we hosted 17 listening sessions and you'll see all the dates listed and some dates we doubled up uh

[02:34:50] there we were there in the the afternoon and the evening and you'll see all the different stakeholder groups that we met with we started with superintendents and division leaders we met with elementary school principals secondary school principals teachers parents school board members we met with representatives from different student groups so we had a good representation from students with disabilities and we really listened we dispelled some myths because there were a lot of questions and there were some things like okay let's get that accurate and then we really listened to what supports they wanted we listened to their concerns regarding

[02:35:30] timeline and implementation and we also listened to their support they were we had they it was clear they're not afraid of the higher expectations they just want the time and support to get there so it was over 1 000 participants in our during our virtual sessions and then we had online forms and we had over 1500 virginians complete that online form and share their feedback and this represented teachers parents community members school division leaders and students

[02:36:05] and i'm going to share a high level overview of some overarching themes and the first set of overarching themes i'm on slide nine focus on the implementation on the time frame and overwhelmingly this idea of use this year as a preparation year they were very concerned if we had two different cut scores one in the fall and then the higher one in the spring what that would do to kids who are testing in the fall and then the next group of kids who are who are testing in the spring and in school

[02:36:45] divisions they really want time and additional resources to prepare so they they want to take this year to prepare with some strategic support from us it's not just them we want to provide some additional support to prepare the school divisions. Overwhelmingly we heard implement a five-year phased-in model.

[02:37:04] Some participants want it longer and we heard from our attack from the recommendations is you know to keep it short and our divisions are saying make it go long and so we're trying to find that sweet spot. We also talked about the approaching performance level. We wanted to ensure that this was adding this performance level was something that the field wanted and overwhelmingly yes they want the approaching performance level they want the approaching performance level to count as passing and they

want the approaching performance level to to count as proficient in the accountability system during this phase

[02:37:40] in period one slide 10 you'll see just some quotes from that we pulled from the surveys and from some of the chats that were written in our virtual feedback and it all was around a lot of it was around the time having a longer model the five-year model there you can see that their support in support of the recommendation but but they just don't want the change to happen this school year I'm having this what some people were calling the zero year on slide 11 when we asked the participants well what support do you want from the state

[02:38:18] we heard they want guidance on some of the policy around verified credit retakes automatic enrollment in advanced math we want to take this the rest of this year to make sure that we have that guidance nice and solid for them. We heard from principals that they want information shared directly with them, that they don't always get the information that we share at the division level and they recognize that some of this information can help them.

[02:38:44] And so we are planning to partner even closer with our principal organizations to make sure that we're getting materials in the hands of principals so that they can make informed decisions and that they are aware of what's happening, what resources are available. We want to make sure that we are strengthening that communication with principals. That came up loud and clear during the listening sessions. Tutoring was a it was another big thing to have more tutoring resources and more interventions. You know I think All In kicked off a really great thing in the state and nobody wants it to stop and so

[02:39:20] having the continuing those that tutoring and just expanding it across more grade levels and targeting having some targeted tutoring for our students with disabilities and students who are performing at a lower level and then communication that was another big piece that we heard they want some of our leaders so like we just need some clear communication that we can easily share with parents that gives us the snapshot of why do we raise cut scores what supports are available why is this good for their kids why is this good for Virginia and so they want that communication support they want to be

[02:39:59] clear on the supports for students and the implementation timeline and those instructional resources aligned to standards and to the test items because we know to perform well on a test yes you need to know the standards but then also you need to understand the structure of the tests and what it will take what type of questions you need to be able to answer to get to that proficiency level so all of those little things and they're like we want that and we want that right now and then overwhelmingly what we heard was support for students with disabilities that

[02:40:33] came across loud and clear we heard from parents we heard from teachers even in that our surveys we we heard it and so we have our deputy here who's going to talk about support for students with with disabilities and I will thank you so much I just want to say one how appreciative the department is on the overwhelming participation of families and parents of students with disabilities and educators and administrators from across the Commonwealth we know that our sped folks are always mobilized so I'm just really grateful for all the opportunity that the deputy superintendent and particularly mr. Jennings provided for us to

[02:41:11] participate in the listening sessions and I 100% echo the information that was shared today I think what we hear from folks is that they are they are a hundred percent behind the board's mission and vision around expectations for students and I had so many folks talk about the improvements they've seen

with implementation of the Virginia Literacy Act and work the department has done thus far but we did hear very clearly that while they are excited they need time and they want time to receive information and support from the department that we are very focused on providing and so that phased in approach will give time not only for the agency but for school divisions in order for us to broadly disseminate guidance and information to help articulate and

[02:41:51] further identify alternative ways to demonstrate students with disabilities growth and performance over time and to help support those individualized pathways for learning we know that school divisions have the ability to make this work for students with disabilities and our role is to support them in doing that and most importantly we need to conduct outreach to ensure that school division staff and families fully understand our guidance and can support their students along the pathway to graduation. I'm happy to answer any additional questions. I know the board has also received a lot of feedback from the field and so I'll remain on stage as the deputy finishes our presentation as

[02:42:24] well in case there are any specific questions. Thank you. Now what I am really excited about and what the team has been working hard on are revised reports for it'll be for parents, for divisions, for schools. We have been working very very closely with our assessment partners and on slide 13 what you see is the current student performance report this is what parents

[02:42:59] receive and and it provides an overview it's very clear of how your child did what performance level they scored in and then there's a page two that gives information about the reporting category and how your child performing that performance category and then how you can support your child's learning so this was a great first step and with these new cut scores i'm like we have the opportunity to really take this to a whole other level and so it has been great working with mr ellis and his team

[02:43:32] and mr jennings and his team and hearing from the listening sessions about the type of how they want things communicated and so in spring of 2026 you will see new student reports for the what will be for that administration of that spring 2026 assessment and what these reports they're going to provide a clearer and more supportive picture of student performance so what you're going to see is both the how the student performs under this current cut score of 400 and then where they're

[02:44:08] expected to and then how that with that same score where they would perform with the revised cut score so this will give parents that clear picture even before the cut scores are implemented this is how how your child is performing under the current this is where they would be under the revised cut scores there'll be some very clear parent friendly language and we're going to get very clear about what are the the questions what are the items that the students did well on and where did they experience challenge so when you go to slide 15 you'll see our initial mock-up and we are going to take this around and get some additional feedback we're looking forward to going to the

[02:44:48] the superintendent's conference and taking this with us to get their feedback on some of this but what you'll see are these gauges and you'll see two gauges and it'll highlight so the bars are great the gauge is great out except for where your child perform and you'll see on one side is the performance under the current cut score and then on the second the second gauge is the performance under the revised cut score and then right beneath that these are the overarching categories that the student was tested on and how they performed and you'll see where the child will need additional

[02:45:25] support or where they demonstrated a strong understanding and then when you go to page two you'll get that detailed breakdown of where they needed support where they met the learning goal, and

where they really excelled.

[02:45:41] And so you'll be able to see very clearly if the test item was a hard, medium, or low test item, or high, medium, or low test item, and then there'll be some more resources to support that parents can access on this page.

[02:45:57] And so we are very excited about these revised parent reports, and we're like i said we're getting more feedback and we're going to work with our assessment partners to to get this right so that the next iteration of reporting you'll see it in a very different way and so our next steps we recognize we we didn't hear from all parents we didn't hear from um there's still more principals we want to talk with and so we we're going to keep this road show going so we're going to hold additional listening sessions and we're going to keep the

[02:46:34] feedback forms open until november 6th at noon and so stay tuned we want to collect we want to make sure that we are hearing and we're honoring the voices um from the field and um and we're going to host some more support sessions for principals we heard them loud and clear and we're going to make this a continuing thing we don't just want to come to them when we need their feedback we want to make this an ongoing thing with our leaders across the state and then we're going to continue preparing to support to prepare support for divisions so um for instance we are we know that mr ellis team they're working on the performance level descriptors and and test items

[02:47:14] that can be released in uh in item mapping we have the instruction team i mentioned the just in time math quick checks they're doing some small virtual learning sessions where teachers can log on to these self-paced modules um to to see some effective uh literacy instruction and learn some some things around just some foundational reading skills and we're going to uh release and start going out into the field a lot more and so we are very excited about just this next steps and we are going to finalize revisions to the assessment reports in preparation for that spring

[02:47:49] 20 in preparation for spring 2026. so with that we'll open the floor up to questions hi thank you you very much for that presentation I'm excited to hear that we're being cautious and picking this right and doing this timeline right you know I've said in previous meetings the impact the impact is the other discussion right wait setting the scores and we've done that we've done the job and we all believed in that unanimously but impact and now we're here right now we're at that and that impact discussion and and obviously I've heard a lot from my colleagues in

[02:48:25] field of special education and what this means to them um and and this may not be a question it may just be more consideration for you all as you're you're collecting data for november but um and maybe it's time too for the the board to hear one of my favorite educational quotes of all time it's it's charles schwab he said this in a fortune 500 magazine he's a financial guru he says the a students work for the b students the c students are the ceos but the d students on all the buildings and one thing I love about revolutionizing all this is we're kind of countering that what's broken in education right I mean I think this is really trying to address that and there's so many key I try to tell

[02:49:03] folks when I talk to them there's so many key components of this change that's geared for students with special needs like these parental reports I think it's my favorite part of the whole process for parents to have insight and how their students are performing on these assessments and assessments that they may have to take for entrance exams into colleges and other things it kind of informs them in that way but one thing i do want us to consider is uh you know the one of those answers to charles schwab

challenge of the a students and the d students is differentiated instruction right um those of us in the field actually a lot of us should know about differentiated instruction because it's not just rooted in special ed anymore it's it's roots are in gifted

[02:49:42] ed ironically but special ed is notorious for it but when you do special differentiated instruction you also do differentiated assessment and so I know we already have some things in place already in Virginia but as we're considering these scores and what it means to you know I think it's great for the schools and the teachers that have that level of accountability but yeah I when you're in special ed and I know Dr. Hollins can appreciate this we get to think about Johnny right like we we have a name that goes with the score and so just making sure we're being mindful of of the type of accommodations differentiation that we can also do with this type of assessment and maybe

[02:50:18] there is something in that you can speak to or it's just for consideration but definitely hearing from our colleagues parents as I'm sure you are as well so absolutely and we're so appreciative of those remarks as well I think what I appreciate most about the board's approach to this work is not only the consistency and the goal but the flexibility to think about the impact component And I spent my day yesterday with 101 out of 131 of our school divisions and 600-plus special education teachers, general education teachers, and building-level administrators doing exactly what Member Aikerman just talked about,

[02:50:54] and that is helping to support them in the building blocks for success for students with disabilities, getting them the professional development and the technical assistance and support they need so they can go back and lead their buildings focused on that work. And the more time we have to do that, the more time we have to assure our school divisions of what they're capable of and support them appropriately, the better it will be for our students and families.

[02:51:17] Other comments? Dr. Northern? I've got one for, I guess, you and then one for Tiara. I'm wondering on the IEPs for the students with disabilities, and I know we're redoing that and trying to make that consistent, But will those IEPs be tied to these Xs where they need additional support?

[02:51:43] Can we make the connection between the IEP and where we know students with disabilities are struggling? Absolutely, Dr. Northam. I mean, I think you just spoke to the fact the whole purpose behind an IEP is to be an individualized plan for a student. And as Dr. Ackerman just commented, there are so many things to think about in providing a high-quality instruction for our students with disabilities.

[02:52:03] But that IEP should be focused on specially designed instruction to address the impact area of a student's disability on their educational performance. And so you heard Dr. Ballard talk eloquently about ensuring the high quality tier one instruction for all of our students. That is only going to contribute to enhanced outcomes for students with disabilities.

[02:52:23] It's our role in special education to bridge the gaps there with things like specially designed instruction to make sure that those plant one, our students are found eligible. right we talked a little bit about earlier today great President Creasy's remarks on identification and evaluation eligibility we need to know who our kids are and how their disability impacts them we need to build a plan and a blueprint to help them be successful that's the IEP and then we need to make sure that work is being done in our classroom and alongside their general education peers because we know that inclusive environments impact academic performance for students so absolutely that's a huge part of what we're focused on in our professional development from the department okay I guess my question

[02:53:02] is really more on the infrastructure like will the ip that format that we're building will it be able to actually pull from the data that's you you know where they have these needs additional support areas and will those two to your knowledge will those infrastructures be able to talk to each other the ip infrastructure and the school report card infrastructure to to sort of you know pull from one for the other in terms of how these um you know where the kids specifically need help The way that we have built Virginia IEP, it is talking to a student information system at the division and school-based level to share that information data across platforms.

[02:53:38] And you might remember previously the updates on the new state funding that was allocated to support Virginia IEP also funded increased progress monitoring for students on an individualized and holistic level. So absolutely. Okay, that's great. Yeah, a great question. Thank you so much for bringing that to our attention, too.

[02:53:56] Go ahead. Tiara. I'm just wondering, and this is like a huge step forward on the, you know, on the student report card. I'm just excited about what I'm seeing with AI already being able to leverage very specific student supports and direction to parents. And I don't know, I think you're working with, what's it, WAIF? I don't know whether they have done this in other states yet, but where you can literally say you know dear and then you it fills in the parents the guardian's

[02:54:34] name and then it fills in your child it's like a paragraph literally that like talks to them you know instead of like a chart or whatever and it'll say you know because your student doesn't you know do this and it's all written in parent-friendly language here's a resource that other parents have used you know click here like it's really like i've seen it like a narrative that occurs at the you know at the bottom that's just like a letter to them like a word and it used their names use their kids names and anyway it just has a more of a personalized element to it and i really think that some states are just starting to see how ai can be used to customize a parental communication

[02:55:12] in a way that feels more personalized um you know than than other ways that we've had done in the past we were actually talking about that we so that did come up in our discussions with our assessment vendor and what are what are your capabilities on doing that and we are excited that we will be starting the innovative assessment group and we're going to definitely bring that to the table because there's there's a ton of things you can do now with reporting and how can we leverage that you know even down to there some states where you you could get the data very quickly and we

[02:55:48] get data can come very quickly to our school divisions and at the state we have to do a little bit more, but how can you take that data and then immediately inform instruction? So there's a lot happening now with assessments that we are so excited about that innovative assessment work group that we're about to launch to get those ideas going. Anything else? Mr. Monk?

[02:56:13] Just quickly, I appreciate the new report card for parents. I think that's just an integral part of all of this and the communication to them. One thing would just encourage the framing around, And I see some language here, but maybe revisit what future expectations means, because I think now with, unfortunately, the politicization of education, it's all, you know, raising the bar and all of those things.

[02:56:42] But I think just grounding that in reality of where, why that happened. I know we've only got a small paragraph, but I don't want folks to say, oh, that's this entity or this group or this fraction that is saying that. But this is really a level set of where our learners are and where we know that they can be.

[02:57:00] And I think that just that messaging is so important, especially on this report card piece. Definitely. We're going to be working with our partners at Waypoint for that. So, yes, we will get that language right for parents. So, I mean, you guys have heard me harp on this time and time again with all of these things.

[02:57:19] But speaking of the report, how, what's the plan for supporting schools and teachers and how they communicate with parents? Because we've talked about, you know, all our different measurement tools, you know, our growth measurements and our SOL results and how, you know, how are we going to be using these tools so that it's literally not just a piece of paper that goes home in the folder at the end of the school year.

[02:57:50] but that teachers are really equipped with how to sit down with parents and talk these things out or to be, you know, to have that open time to be able to say, parents, please come in or let's do a Zoom or whatever it is to be able to communicate effectively on how do we move the needle?

[02:58:11] Maybe we're not where we should be this year, but let's talk about how we get there for next year because I do think it opens up a totally different line of communication with parents and families and the school to be able to do that and so you know as we continue to talk about how we've got this well-rounded means by which we improve student outcomes that's inclusive of families I just want to make sure that we're reiterating that piece too definitely and so this is where that training well first we need to make sure we have we've built the capacity of the

[02:58:45] teachers to to know how to read these reports how to use them and then the different test items in those performance level descriptors what do they mean how do you use them in instruction we want to make sure they have strong capacity around that because then that'll totally shift how they're talking to parents because they have that deeper understanding and with the race cut scores and students answering and responding to more rigorous questions we have to make sure the teachers understand what are these questions look like what type of skills are they are they um addressing you heard from the

[02:59:21] presentation earlier from dr perry around like the complexity of the item and the difficulty level and the cognitive load we have to break all of that down for these test items and ensure that our teachers understand so that then they can when they're talking with the parent they can communicate that in a way that's very clear but if our teachers aren't sure and they're not really then it's not that communication um won't be effective so that is what we're spending the time for this preparation year doing and then finally just another question on really the report

[02:59:55] and the specifics of the distribution how is that happening is it gonna be well first are the how are the reports how are they created number one are they coming out of the test system this might be for jason uh the test system itself individually per student and then are they being electronically delivered to parents are they being delivered in paper form you know how are we ensuring that parents who may not have the ability for one reason or the other to receive it in electronic form are actually getting it just want to make sure that we have all of those bases covered for

[03:00:34] those who are in the public watching us have this conversation now yeah so i'll turn it over to miss ellis who's going to go into detail with that and even talk about the turnaround how quickly parents can receive these reports good morning everyone good to have the opportunity to speak to you again in regards to reporting from our standards of learning and even the the vap assessments as well reporting is often available within about 24 hours after the student has completed the test and that's assuming that a

test is not in alerted status that there's not something that has to to be cleared up or accommodation coded before it can be reported.

[03:01:12] So Virginia is pretty strong at getting the information from the assessment back to schools and divisions. It's been policy for as long as I can remember that school divisions can create their local policy in how they disseminate that information to parents.

[03:01:32] We have some school divisions that will roll it out very quickly. We have some school divisions that will hold that information and send it out with the next report card or send it out at the end of the school year, depending on when they were testing. So I don't know that there's one answer to your question.

[03:01:49] I think there's many answers to your questions because we have allowed divisions for years to create their policy for how they provide the information to parents. The reports themselves are available in several different ways. Divisions could print them themselves if they wanted to incur that cost.

[03:02:07] We do have, as part of our contract with our assessment vendor, school divisions are able to request printed reports. Once the test administration is over, they finalize their data, and then they are able to say we would like this series of reports.

[03:02:23] There's many they can choose from. The parent report is one of those. So our vendor would print the reports, send them to them, and then they can disseminate them however they would choose to. One of the things that we also would need to consider is we allow school divisions. It's again, it's it's been our practice previously is school divisions aren't required to use our reports.

[03:02:45] They're required to provide that information to families. So we do have some divisions that take the information that we provide and then they have their own data systems and such that they use and they will create their own reporting that will then go to families.

[03:03:01] So, like I said, there's no one answer to all of those questions because we've allowed divisions flexibility. May I? Dr. Ackerman, just a follow-up on that. I have the luxury of working with about 100 different school systems, and I can verify what you're saying as they all come to us very differently.

[03:03:20] and also to address Dr. Northern's comment around the IEP the Virginia IEP will be a huge solution for getting that disseminated quicker to parents and other partners to the school divisions like who I'm familiar with so I think that would be a solution for some continuity amount among how all the different counties and cities are doing it but it but it's fascinating as I'm sure people who work with multiple communities know the different ways they get that information on the assessments out to people and whether it's timely or not to be honest so um i do think the virginia iep salute will but that will only then address the students with

[03:03:59] disabilities um and other parents i think still get them at varying times at the in current practice so so that kind of leads me to a thought but i'll let dr northern go first um this may be tiara again um as i'm studying this um couple things one what some states do is they also put the course grades on here because we've been talking a lot about the quote honesty gap and what happens is the test scores and the course grades you know often look very different and so some states are including the course grades and saying you know here's why

[03:04:38] you might see some differences or you know here's why they don't align or here's why you would expect them to or not to align and I get like this could become a report card book and I so I understand we want to keep it but I do I'm looking at Ed Navigator they do a lot of good you know they look at report cards all across the country and they make that point that sometimes it's very powerful to include the course grades and think about when we were in school that's what this was right it was your course grades that your parents had to sign so I do think we ought to have that discussion and as you go around and see what folks think about putting that in addition to

[03:05:16] the test scores because I think it's an important piece and the other piece is absences I don't see a place on here where we have absences and that's another piece that would tie into you know our push on absenteeism that you know we need to kind of wave the flag here for that thank you for those suggestions we'll definitely take that back for consideration so I mean that's gonna you know that's maybe maybe we need some more information from Mr. Ellis on whether or not we're capable of determining what school divisions are actually using the reports that DOE is providing versus

[03:05:53] their own reports is it something that you know the board can say these reports are what you need to use or is it something that the board can say this is the timing in which you deliver those reports outside of extenuating circumstances? I mean, I would imagine that's probably within the purview of the board, but I don't know that to be certain. May I? I'm sorry. Just because of my experience with it, I think it depends on the resources that the school division has to do those things and then how we resource them to be able to do it. So if the DOE and the board

[03:06:33] provides the resource and form that makes it automated or simple or the use of AI or the way the systems speak, I think that could be something we could consider. But, you know, when you have those smaller systems who the one person, you know, your superintendent's also your testing coordinator, I think that's where we have seen we are slower to get a response on students' progress.

[03:06:58] So, Ms. Kilgore? I was sitting here the whole time he was speaking and sharing that, and I was thinking, Does it have to be that way? I mean, can we not have, I don't know, not necessarily require it to be a certain time, but at least a window of time?

[03:07:14] Because I just don't think it's, I think it's crucial. It becomes an effective date. Right. And I know we'll get to this later in the day, but talking about board's priorities and a student information system, and so I don't know the legality of what is within the board's purview, but I think that if we were to look at a student information system At minimum, we might be able to provide that information to a parent directly in that way.

[03:07:42] So food for thought there. But kind of agree, if we're doing all this work and the information isn't shared directly or timely, then, you know, it causes some challenges. No, not at all.

[03:08:01] I mean. Perhaps it's been a point of consternation for you as well. We receive calls every year. And so I'll refer to this anecdotally. So we receive calls every year from families asking for their SOL reports.

[03:08:22] Our office's policy has always been that the owner of that data is the local school division. So we refer that parent back to their local school division. There's no way we could verify that we're actually talking to Johnny's mom or dad. So we leave that as a responsibility for the local school division.

[03:08:41] With that said, sometimes we're receiving those calls in August or September when testing happened the previous spring. So anecdotally, I can tell you that there are some places or some people that aren't getting their assessment results until many days or many weeks or many months after the actual assessment was taken.

[03:09:02] So from an effectiveness perspective, if I'm a parent and I'm highly engaged in my child's education, I lose a summer's worth of time where I could possibly be getting them support in areas where they're struggling. So, yes, this conversation is something that we have talked about many times.

[03:09:21] You know, how do we get the reports into parents' hands more quickly? To speak to a point that was brought up earlier, we have utilized what I think are some innovative things. With our the parent portal that we have it's optional for divisions to use but we do have a Personalized video that lives in that parent portal that basically takes what you see is page two on that parent report And it explains them how to utilize that information It's a short video because no one's going to watch a 20-minute video on how to use it So it's really just kind of a highlight about a process that they can use

[03:10:01] But it is personalized to their student. I mean, it calls their student by name. It gives them information about the, you know, the report that they're looking at with some real examples. So we have stepped out on that ledge a little bit to provide some more innovative things.

[03:10:18] So consternation, yes. And does the board have the ability to say something needs to come out this many weeks, this many days after, you know, the assessment's been provided?

[03:10:34] I don't know. Would it be helpful? It may be helpful to some divisions or some families that are in divisions where maybe the report doesn't come out as quickly. We would have to survey our divisions to find out what their individual policies are for when they provide reports to families.

[03:10:53] in order to kind of give you some more feedback or some more information. We could certainly do that and, you know, at the direction of the board. Do we have any idea how many divisions are actually using the parent portal? And how are we communicating?

[03:11:12] I mean, are we considering leadership turnovers and all kinds of things like that? How regularly are we communicating this option? So we have trained divisions typically in the fall the last several years about the parent portal, its availability.

[03:11:30] I would say, very generically speaking, it's a small percentage of school divisions that are using the parent portal. We have some school divisions that use it a lot. It's their means for getting information out. They utilize it in part because then they don't have to print the reports.

[03:11:49] They can use that portal as their means for getting the information to families. The good part about the portal is information is updated in the portal every Friday. And so typically, if a student completes a test in, let's say, week A, at the end of week B, those results will be in the portal.

[03:12:07] And we need a little bit of time to set everything up and push it out. Again, all that's through our current assessment contractor. But, I mean, it certainly is, I see it as a valuable tool. I understand from a division perspective, many of them already have their own education portals that parents are familiar with and have access to.

[03:12:29] And this is something different that they would have to access. From a division perspective, there's a claim code that has to be provided. You're fine. Mike, don't get along. There's a claim code that has

to be provided to families every test administration, which in Virginia, that's a fall spring situation. So it's two a year potentially.

[03:12:53] So there are some things that I could see could be a little bit of adherence to divisions to want to use it. But I do think it's a valuable tool. We not only put the reports out there and the videos, but they have access to that historically. So a parent who has had access to the portal for the last three years, they have a historical perspective of all of their students' test history. So again, I think it's a valuable tool that if we could find a way to generate more,

[03:13:27] you know, more usage, it could be a very good thing. My next question, what can we do to get the word out so to speak i mean yeah i know these are said and done obviously now you've thought about this many times and i'm just thinking out loud you know i'm old enough to remember when my children were taking sols in third grade and you already know it was probably june or july before you knew the results back in the dark ages so we're not there anymore so i would think there's surely some way um to make it more to make it more aware to more people than it is now and i don't

[03:14:07] what that is sure well i don't i don't necessarily think it's an awareness issue as much as it is a it's it's another thing to do for some folks oh yeah yeah sure sure yeah other comments here okay i think we're good maybe we want to look at you know what what is the flexibility of the board to put some parameters around release um you know uh score release information um that would help

[03:14:43] parents and families uh have a little quicker turnaround and be able to support their students better during the summer months um and then you know let's let's try to figure out you know is there a means by which you know because i hate for the amount of work that's been put into to this particular new report mechanism to not be fully utilized the way that it should be um

[03:15:13] so uh let's look at what our our purview is there too if we can thank you thanks uh superintendent gallixson i know you had some things that you'd like to add here all right well we can definitely come back um with the help of mr ellis and his team on what are sort of the most effective and best practices that we know of to help inform the board and get back to you on the score release parameters next month I also want to note that in addition to

[03:15:48] all of the great data points from just the last board meeting to now the team also touched base with over 600 additional Virginians prior to our last board meeting to help inform and be thoughtful about once we set these higher expectations for our students what do you need what does that look like and so we're continuing those input sessions and are so appreciative of the active engagement information full sessions of feedback in chat in written

[03:16:26] form verbally and our team is so grateful for that we have heard requests from families that they have more would like to be able to participate and so as you heard from our deputy superintendent we're going to continue for those next two weeks to get more input from families and have heard from our educators on you know we are fully supportive of higher expectations and need some help on communicating this why to our parents and families and helping them bridge how

[03:17:04] we're going to help get every student there which the team's underway we also i want to underscore the note on the powerpoint about continuing host support sessions for principals some of our principals have already been deeply collaborative with their division leadership looking and digging into their impact data making adjustments and others have requested a direct line of communication with the

agency and so whether some of that data is not being handed out or it's being handed out but not actually reaching

[03:17:43] those individual school leaders we want to make sure that they've got a little bit more time and we're happy to help get that to them directly but those were some of the elements and so as you all know we do have an additional board meeting in two and a half weeks and so we're gonna keep the board up to date on the additional inputs for finalizing some of these next steps we are going to

[03:18:13] move item e to after our legal issues closed session so with that I would ask mr. Hansen if he would read us into our closed meeting so that we can receive legal advice I move that the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes consultation with legal counsel employed by or retained by a public body regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice by such

[03:18:51] counsel pursuant to section 2.2-3711 of the code of virginia and that legal counsel to virginia board of education and staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting okay dr ackerman or i need a second sorry i need a second second uh dr ackerman aye mr green aye dr northern aye mr hanson miss kilgore mr monk

[03:19:21] aye and chair votes aye okay we are going into closed session thank you we are back um so mr

[04:54:28] hanson will you read our certification to return to open session please we convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the freedom of Information Act. Section 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia requires that the Board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter, and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard, discussed, or considered. Any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote, indicating the substance of the departure that in his or her judgment

[04:55:07] has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. Okay. Second. I need a second. Second. Dr. Ackerman. Aye. Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Mr. Hansen. Aye.

[04:55:22] Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. And chair votes aye. We will be taking a 20-minute lunch break,

[04:55:31] so we'll be back here 2.05, and we'll see you then. From lunch, and what we are going to do

[05:28:54] from here is we will be moving items E and F. E is our federal updates as a state plan ed flex and then our discussion of the board's prescriptions on the standards of quality those will be moved to tomorrow's agenda E and F will be moved to tomorrow's agenda and we will conclude our day today with our

[05:29:27] licensure cases so we will be back after our licensure cases are complete so that being said Mr. Hanson will you read us into closed session for licensure cases thank you madam president I move that the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes discussion or consideration by the Board of Education of information relating to denial, suspension, or revocation of teacher licenses subject to the exclusion in subdivision 11 of section 2.2-3705.2 pursuant to section 2.2-3711

[05:30:07] A40 of the Code of Virginia and consultation with counsel regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice pursuant to Virginia Code Section 2.2-3711A8 of the Code of Virginia and the legal counsel to Virginia Board of Education staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting.

[05:30:32] Dr. Ackerman. Second and aye. Thank you. Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Mr. Hansen. Aye. Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. And chair votes aye.

[05:30:48] We are in closed session.

[05:30:50] thank you. Okay. Dr. Northern, would you please read our motion to come out of closed session?

[06:34:41] Yes. We convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act, Section 22-3712 of the Code of Virginia, requires that the board certify, to the best of each member's knowledge, one, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter, and two, only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard, discussed, or considered. Any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote, indicating the substance of

[06:35:18] the departure that, in his or her judgment, has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. Dr. Ackerman? Aye. Mr. Green? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr.

[06:35:36] Monk? Aye. Chair votes aye. Okay. Let's see. In case 2025-36, the chair would like to entertain a motion to revoke the license of Ashley Mache Corvington. Second. Dr. Ackerman. Aye. Mr. Green.

[06:36:09] Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Ms. Kilgore. Mr. Monk. Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. In case 2025-39, the chair will entertain a motion to issue a license. So move. Second. Dr. Ackerman. Aye. Mr.

[06:36:32] Green? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Monk? Aye. And chair votes aye. In case 2025-37, the chair will entertain a motion to issue a license. So moved. Second. Dr. Ackerman? Aye. Mr.

[06:36:50] Green? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Mr. Monk? Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. um and that concludes our licensure items and um just as a reminder miss at the beginning of the meeting i had noted the remote participation of miss mcpherson and just wanted to reiterate that uh for the record and um superintendent gallickson before we uh adjourn for the day

[06:37:23] do you need to make any remarks okay all right and with that we are adjourned for the day